

HONORÉ DE BALZAC

PAR

THÉOPHILE GAUTIER

ÉDITION REVUE ET AUGMENTÉE, AVEC UN PORTRAIT
GRAVÉ A L'EAU-FORTE

PAR

E. HÉDOUIN



PARIS

POULET-MALASSIS ET DE BROISE

LIBRAIRES-ÉDITEURS

9, rue des Beaux-Arts

1859

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HONORÉ DE BALZAC
BY
THÉOPHILE GAUTIER

REVISED AND EXPANDED EDITION

PARIS
POULET-MALASSIS ET DE BROISE
BOOKSELLERS-PUBLISHERS
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1859

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I

Around 1835, I lived in two small rooms in the Impasse du Doyenné, not far from the current location of the Pavillon Mollien. Although it was located in the center of Paris facing the Tuilleries and just a few steps from the Louvre, the location was deserted and wild, and it required a certain persistence for me to be found. However, one morning a young man with a distinguished look and a cordial and spiritual air approached my front door and excused himself while making his introduction; he was Jules Sandeau: he had come to recruit me on behalf of Balzac for *La Chronique de Paris*, a weekly journal that one will certainly remember, but which had not been as financially successful as it deserved. Balzac, Sandeau told me, had read *Mademoiselle de Maupin*, then very recently published, and he had very much admired its style; thus he wished to request my collaboration on the journal that he sponsored and directed. A date was set for us to get together, and from that date forward there was between us a friendship that only death could break.

If I have told this story, it is not because it is flattering for me, but because it honors Balzac, who, already famous, sought out a young, obscure writer to collaborate in a spirit of camaraderie and complete equality. At that time, it's true, Balzac was not yet the author of *La Comédie Humaine*, but he had completed, besides several novellas, *La Physiologie du Mariage*, *La Peau de Chagrin*, *Louis Lambert*, *Seraphita*, *Eugénie Grandet*, *l'Histoire des Treize*, *Le Médecin de Campagne*, *Père Goriot*, that is to say, in ordinary times, enough to solidify five or six reputations. His nascent glory, strengthened each month with new rays, shined with all of the splendors of the aurora; certainly he shined brightly like his contemporaries Lamartine, Victor Hugo, de Vigny, de Musset, Sainte-Beuve, Alexandre Dumas, Mérimée, George Sand, and many others; but at no time in his life did Balzac carry himself as the Grand Lama of literature, and he was always good company; he had pride, but he was entirely free of vanity.

He lived at that time at the end of the Jardin du Luxembourg, near the Observatoire, on a little frequented road given the name of Cassini, without doubt because of its astronomical neighbor. On the garden wall which occupied almost the entire side, and at the end of which was found the house in which Balzac lived, one read: *Labsolu, brick merchant*. That strange sign, which is still there, if I am not wrong, is very striking; *La Recherche de l'Absolu* can have no other inspiration. This fateful name

probably suggested to the author the idea of Balthasar Claës in the pursuit of his impossible dream.

When I saw him for the first time, Balzac, one year older than the century, was around thirty-six, and his face was one of those that one would never forget. In his presence, one is reminded of Shakespeare's lines about Julius Caesar: "Before him, nature stands up boldly and says to the world, 'This is a man!'"

My heart beat strongly because never had I approached without trembling a master of thought, and all the speeches I had prepared on the way stayed in my throat, allowing nothing to pass other than a stupid phrase like this: "The temperature is nice today." Heinrich Heine, when he went to visit Goethe, could find nothing to say except that the plums that have fallen from the trees on the route from Iéna to Weimar are excellent for thirst, which made the Jupiter of German poetry laugh gently. Balzac, seeing my embarrassment, soon put me at my ease, and during breakfast I became calm enough to examine him in detail.

He wore, in the form of a dressing gown, a robe of white cashmere or flannel held at the waist by a cord, in which, some time later, he was painted by Louis Boulanger. What whim had pushed him to choose, ahead of any other, this costume that he never took off? Could it be that it symbolized in his eyes the cloistered life to which his labors condemned him, and, Benedictine of the novel, he had thus taken the robe? This robe always suited him marvelously. He boasted, showing me the intact sleeves, to have never sullied its purity with the least stain of ink, "because," he said, "the true writer should always be neat while at his work."

His robe, thrown back, revealed the neck of an athlete or a bull, round as a section of a column, without apparent muscles, and of a satiny whiteness which contrasted with the deeper hue of his face. At this time, Balzac, in the prime of his life, gave the impression of a robust health, little in harmony with the romantic pallors then in fashion. The pure Tourainian blood left his cheeks a bright purple and warmly colored his lips, thick and sinuous, easy to laugh; a light mustache and a small beard just below his lower lip accentuated the contours of his mouth, without concealing them; the nose, square at the end, divided into two lobes, pierced by very open nostrils, of a character entirely original and unique; Balzac, in posing for his bust, told the sculptor, David d'Angers, "Be careful about my nose, my nose is a world!" The forehead was beautiful, vast, noble, much whiter than the face, with no creases other than a perpendicular furrow along the ridge of the nose; there was a very pronounced ridge above the eyebrows; the hair, abundant, long, strong and black, stood up in back like a lion's mane. As for

the eyes, there have never existed anything comparable. They had a life, a light, an inconceivable magnetism. Despite the nightly vigils, their whites were pure, limpid, bluish, like that of a child or a virgin, and encased two black diamonds that shined at times with rich reflections of gold: they were eyes to make eagles avert their gaze, to penetrate walls and hearts, to strike down a furious wild beast, the eyes of the sovereign, the seer, the conqueror.

Mme. Emile de Girardin, in her novel entitled *La Canne de M. de Balzac*, speaks of these shining eyes:

"Tancred then perceived at the front of the club, turquoise, gold, marvelous carvings; and behind all of that two large black eyes more brilliant than the stones."

Those extraordinary eyes, once one had met their gaze, made it difficult to notice other features that might have been trivial or irregular.

The habitual expression of the face was a sort of powerful hilarity, a Rabelaisian and monkish joy — the robe no doubt contributing to the birth of this idea — which made you think of Brother Jean des Entommeures, but it was enlarged and elevated by a mind of the first order.

According to his habit, Balzac had risen at midnight, and had written until my arrival. His features betrayed no fatigue, aside from a slight darkening beneath the eyelids, and during the entire breakfast he demonstrated a wild gaiety. Little by little the conversation drifted toward literature, and he complained of the enormous difficulties of the French language. Style preoccupied him a great deal, and he sincerely believed that he had none at all. It is true that he was then generally thought to be lacking this quality. The school of Victor Hugo, in love with the sixteenth century and the Middle Ages, specialized in patterns, in rhythms, in structure, rich in words, breaking prose with the gymnastics of verse, and modeling itself on a master confident in his methods, would do nothing other than that which was *well written*, that is to say worked and toned beyond measure, and found the portrayal of modern manners to be useless, conventional, and lacking in lyricism. Balzac, despite the popularity that he had begun to enjoy among the public, was not admitted among the gods of Romanticism, and he knew it. While devouring his books, people did not pause to regard their serious side, and even for his admirers, he remained for a long time the most productive of our novelists and nothing else; this surprises today, but I can vouch for the truth of my assertion. He tortured himself in trying to achieve a style, and, in his anxiety to make corrections, he consulted people who were a hundred times his inferiors. Before signing his name to anything, he had written under different pseudonyms (Horace de Saint-Aubin, L. de Viellerglé, etc.) one hundred volumes just "to free his

hand." However he already possessed a style of his own without being conscious of it.

But let me return to our breakfast. While talking, Balzac played with his knife or his fork, and I noted that his hands were of a rare beauty, the true hands of a prelate, white, with fingers both slender and plump, and nails that were pink and shiny; he was proud of them and smiled with pleasure as I looked at them. He considered his hands to be evidence of breeding and aristocratic birth. Lord Byron, in a note, says with evident satisfaction, that Ali Pacha complimented him on the smallness of his ears, and inferred from them that he was a true gentleman. A similar remark upon his hands would have equally flattered Balzac, even more than the praise of one his books. He had a sort of prejudice against those whose extremities lacked finesse. The meal was rather fine, a *paté de foie gras* was part of it, but this was a deviation from his habitual frugality, as he remarked while laughing, and that for "this solemn occasion" he had borrowed his silver plates from his library!

I retired after having promised some articles for *La Chronique de Paris*, where *Le Tour en Belgique*, *La Morte Amoureuse*, *La Chaîne d'Or*, and other literary works had appeared. Charles de Bernard, who had also been called by Balzac, contributed *La Femme de Quarante Ans*, *La Rose Jaune*, and some new work since collected into volumes. Balzac, as one knows, had invented the woman of thirty years; his imitator added ten years to that already venerable age and his heroine obtained no less success.

Before going further, let's pause for a moment and give some details of Balzac's life prior to my acquaintance with him. My authorities will be Madame de Surville, his sister, and himself.

Balzac was born in Tours, May 16, 1799, on the day of the celebration of Saint Honoré who gave him his name, which sounded good and augured well. Little Honoré was not a child prodigy; he did not announce prematurely that he would write *La Comédie Humaine*. He was a fresh, rosy, healthy boy, fond of play, with gentle, sparkling eyes, but in no way distinguished from other boys of his age, at least upon casual observation. At seven, upon leaving a day school in Tours, he attended a secondary school in Vendôme run by the Oratoriens, where he was thought to be a very mediocre student.

The first part of *Louis Lambert* contains curious information regarding this period of Balzac's life. Dividing his own personality, he describes himself as an old classmate of Louis Lambert, sometimes speaking in his name, and sometimes lending his own sentiments to this person who is imaginary, yet very real, since he is a sort of lens into the writer's very soul.

"Situated in the middle of the town, upon the little river Loire that bathes its walls, the college forms a vast enclosure containing the establishments necessary for an institution of this kind: a chapel, a theater, an infirmary, a bakery, some streams of water. This college, the most celebrated seat of instruction of the central provinces, is populated by those provinces and by our colonies. The distance does not allow parents to come here often to see their children; the rules forbid vacations away from the institution. Once they have entered, the pupils do not leave the college until the end of their studies. With the exception of walks taken outside under the supervision of the Fathers, everything had been planned to give to this house all of the advantages of monastic discipline. In my time, the corrector was still a living memory, and the leather strap played with honor its terrible role."

It is in this way that Balzac described this formidable college, which left in his imagination such persistent memories.

It would be intriguing to compare the novella titled *William Wilson*, in which Edgar Allen Poe describes, with the strange exaggerations of childhood, the old building from the time of Queen Elizabeth where his hero was raised with a companion who was no less strange than Louis Lambert; but this is not the place to make this comparison, thus I must content myself only to point it out.

Balzac suffered prodigiously in this college, where his tendency to daydream was assaulted every instant by some inflexible rule. He neglected his studies; but, benefitting from the tacit complicity of a tutor of mathematics, who was at the same time a librarian and occupied in studies that were outside of the realm of ordinary experience, he did not take his lessons and borrowed all of the books he wished. He passed all of his time in secret reading. Soon he became the most punished student in the class. Extra work and detentions occupied his recreation time.

For certain schoolchildren, punishments inspire a sort of stoic rebellion, and they oppose the exasperated professors with the same disdainful impassivity that captive savage warriors display toward the enemy who tortures them. Isolation, starvation, and the leather strap will not elicit the least complaint; there are thus between the master and the student some horrible conflicts, unknown to the parents, in which the steadfastness of the martyrs and the skills of the executioner are found equally. Some nervous teachers cannot bear the expressions full of hate, scorn, and threat with which a child of eight or ten years defies them.

Let us consider here some characteristic details that, under the name of Louis Lambert, also describe Balzac. "Accustomed to the open air, the

independence of an education left to chance, the tender care of an old man who cherished him, and thinking while being warmed by the rays of the sun, it was very difficult for him to conform to the rules of the college, to march in line, to live within the four walls of a room in which twenty-four young boys were silent, seated on a wooden bench, each before his desk. His senses possessed a perfection which gave them an exquisite fragility, and they all suffered from this communal life; the exhalations that left the air corrupted, mixed with the odor of a class that was always dirty and encumbered by the remains of our lunches and our snacks, affected his sense of smell, that sense which, connected more directly than the others to the cerebral system, should cause by its derangements some unavoidable shocks to the organ of thought; apart from these atmospheric corruptions, he found in our study halls some spots where each would put his booty, pigeons killed for the feast days or plates stolen from the refectory. Finally our rooms contained an immense stone on which two buckets of water rested where on a rotating basis we went each morning to wash our face and hands, in the presence of the master. Washed only once each day before our awakening, our premises were always dirty. Then, despite the number of windows and the height of the door, the air was always fouled by the emanations of the wash house, the garbage dump, by the thousand activities of every schoolboy, without counting our eighty bodies when assembled. This kind of a collective humidity, when combined with the dirt that we would carry back from our travels, resulted in an unbearable stench. The deprivation of air that was pure and scented with the countryside in which he had until then lived, the change in his routines, and the discipline all saddened Lambert. His head always leaning on his left hand and his arm supported by his desk, he passed his study time by looking at the foliage of the trees or the clouds in the sky. He seemed to be studying his lessons; but seeing his pen immovably fixed and his page remaining blank, the professor would cry out to him: "You are doing nothing, Lambert."

To this vivid and truthful description of the miseries of life at school, let me add an extract in which Balzac characterizes himself as a duality under the double sobriquet Pythagoras and the Poet, one carried by the half of himself personified in *Louis Lambert* and the other by the half of himself that was his true identity, and which explains admirably why he was seen by his teachers as being an incapable child:

"Our independence, our illicit occupations, our apparent indolence, the torpor in which we remained, our constant punishments, our repugnance toward homework and chores, won us the reputation of being useless and incorrigible boys: our masters despised us, and we similarly fell into the

most terrible discredit among our classmates, from whom we concealed our contraband studies for fear of their mockeries. This double low regard, unjust on the part of the Fathers, was a natural sentiment on the part of our classmates; we didn't know how to play ball, run, or walk on stilts on those days of amnesty when by chance we obtained a moment of freedom; we didn't take part in any of the amusements then in style at the school; strangers to the pleasures of our comrades, we remained alone, seated sadly under a tree in the courtyard. The Poet and Pythagoras were an exception, living a life separate from that of the community. The penetrating instinct, the fragile self-regard of schoolboys, gave them a greater sensitivity with regard to minds that were higher or lower than their own; from there, for some, was hatred of our mute aristocracy; for others, scorn for our uselessness. We held these sentiments between us without our full knowledge, and it's possible that I didn't understand them until today. We lived therefore exactly like two rats skulking in the corner of the room that held our desks, bound there equally during the hours of study and during those of recreation."

The result of these hidden labors, of these meditations which used up study time, was the famous *Traité de la Volonté* about which he spoke many times in *La Comédie Humaine*. Balzac always regretted the loss of this first work that he describes in *Louis Lambert*, and he speaks with an emotion that time has not diminished of the confiscation of the box that held the precious manuscript; some jealous schoolmates tried to snatch the box that two friends fiercely defended: "Suddenly, attracted by the noise of the battle, Father Haugoult roughly intervened and quieted the dispute. This terrible Haugoult ordered us to give the box to him; Lambert handed him the key, the teacher took the papers and flipped through them; then he said while confiscating them: 'So this is the foolishness for which you neglect your work!' Large tears fell from Lambert's eyes, caused as much by the consciousness of his offended sense of moral superiority as by the gratuitous insult and the betrayal that overwhelmed him. Father Haugoult probably sold the *Traité de la Volonté* to a grocer of Vendôme without knowing the importance of the scientific treasures whose seeds were left to die in ignorant hands."

After this passage he adds, "It was in memory of the catastrophe that had happened to Louis's book that in the work with which these studies begin I used for a piece of fiction the title truly invented by Lambert, and that I gave the name (Pauline) of a woman who was dear to him to a young girl who was full of devotion."

In effect, if I open *La Peau de Chagrin*, I find in the confession of Raphael the following words: "You alone admired my *Théorie de la Volonté*, that long work for which I learned the Oriental languages, anatomy, physiology, and to which I dedicated the greatest part of my time, work which, if I am not mistaken, will complete the studies of Mesmer, of Lavater, of Gall, of Bichat, by opening a new path to the human science; there stops my beautiful life, this sacrifice of all of those days, this silkworm's work, unknown to the world, and whose only compensation could be in the work itself; since the end of childhood until the day that I finished my *Theorié*, I have observed, learned, written, read without rest, and my life has seemed like a long chore; a gentle lover of Oriental idleness, enthralled with my dreams, sensual, I have always worked, denying myself the delights of Parisian life; a gourmand, I have been temperate; fond of hikes and journeys on the water, hoping to visit foreign countries, still finding a child's pleasure in skipping stones on the water, I stayed constantly seated with pen in hand; talkative, I went to listen in silence to the public courses at the library and the museum; I slept in my solitary bunk like a devotee of the order of Saint Benedict, and women were however my only fantasy, a fantasy that I caressed but which always escaped me!"

If Balzac regretted the *Traité de la Volonté*, he was less sensitive to the loss of his epic poem on the Incas, which began thusly:

Oh Inca, oh ill-fated and unhappy king!

This unfortunate inspiration earned him, for all of the remaining time that he stayed at the school, the derisory nickname of *poet*. Balzac, it must be confessed, never had a gift for poetry, at least for meter; his complex thoughts rebelled against rhythm.

From these intense meditations, from these truly prodigious intellectual efforts of a child of twelve or fourteen years, there resulted a bizarre malady, a nervous fever, a sort of coma entirely inexplicable for the professors, who were not in on the secret of the readings and the works of young Honoré, who appeared to be so lazy and stupid. No one at the school suspected this precocious excess of intelligence, no one knew that in the cell in which he caused himself to be put daily so as to be at liberty, this student who was thought to be lazy had absorbed an entire library of serious books that were beyond the typical understanding of his age.

Let me here tie together several curious lines related to the reading ability attributed to Louis Lambert, that is to say, Balzac:

"In three years, Louis had assimilated the substance of the books in his uncle's library that deserved to be read. His absorption of ideas by reading had become a curious phenomenon: his eye took in seven or eight lines at a time, and his mind appreciated their meaning at an equal speed. Often a single word in a phrase sufficed for him to appreciate its substance. His memory was prodigious. He remembered with the same fidelity the thoughts acquired by reading as those which reflection or conversation had suggested to him. Ultimately he retained all of those memories: those of places, of names, of words, of things, of figures; not only did he recall objects at will, but he remembered them again lit and colored as they were at the moment that he first perceived them. This power applied equally to the most imperceptible elements of understanding. He remembered not only the placement of thoughts in the book from which he had derived them, but even the disposition of his soul at those distant times."

Balzac retained this marvelous gift of his youth throughout his life, even in larger measure as the years passed, and it is through this that his immense work can be explained, truly the work of Hercules.

The anxious teachers wrote to Balzac's parents to come for him as soon as possible. His mother hurried to him and picked him up to take him back to Tours. The astonishment of the family was great when they saw the thin and sickly child that the school had returned to them in place of the cherub it had received, and it was distressing for Honoré's grandmother. Not only had he lost his beautiful colors and his youthful sturdiness, but, struck by a congestion of ideas, he appeared to be an imbecile. His manner was that of an ecstatic, of a somnambulist who sleeps with his eyes open: lost in a profound reverie, he did not hear that which was said to him, or his mind, returning from afar, arrived too late to respond. But the open air, rest, the nurturing environment of the family, the recreations they forced him to take and the vigorous juices of adolescence soon triumphed over this sickly state. The tumult caused in that young brain by the whirring of ideas diminished. Little by little, the muddled readings became organized; abstractions came to be blended into real images, observations made silently on life; while walking and playing, he studied the pretty landscapes of the Loire, the provincial types, the cathedral of Saint-Gatien and the characteristic physiognomies of the priests and canons; many of the images which later served in the grand fresco of the *Comédie* were sketched during this period of fruitful inaction. However, the intelligence of Balzac was not perceived or understood any more in his family than at school. Even if something clever escaped his lips, his mother, despite being a superior woman, would say to him: "Without a doubt, Honoré, you don't understand

what you are saying." And Balzac would laugh, without further explanation, that wonderful laugh that he had. Balzac's father, who shared qualities at that time with Montaigne, Rabelais, and Uncle Toby, by his philosophy, his originality, and his goodness (it's Madame de Surville who is speaking), had a little better opinion of his son, believing due to certain genetic theories that he held that a child created by himself could not be stupid: nevertheless, he had no suspicion of the great man that he would become in the future.

Balzac's family having returned to Paris, he was entered into the boarding school of Monsieur Lepitre, Rue Saint-Louis, and Messieurs Sganzer and Beuzelin, Rue Thoringy in the Marais. There as at the school in Vendôme, his genius did not reveal itself, and he remained in the midst of the troop of ordinary students. No prefect exclaimed to him: "You will be Marcellus!" or "Thus you shall go to the stars!"

His classes finished, Balzac gave himself that second education which is the true one; he studied, perfected himself, attended the courses of the Sorbonne, and studied law while working with an attorney and a notary. This time, apparently lost, since Balzac became neither an attorney, nor a notary, nor a lawyer, nor a judge, gave him a personal acquaintance with the personnel of the Bazoche and led him to later write what I might call the litigations of *La Comédie Humaine* in the style of a man marvelously versed in that profession.

The examinations passed, the great question of which career to select presented itself. His family wanted to make a notary of Balzac; but the future great writer, who, even though no one believed in his genius, had a consciousness of it himself, refused in a most respectful manner, although they had organized a position on the most favorable terms. His father gave him two years to prove himself, and as the family had returned to the provinces, Madame Balzac installed Honoré in a garret, allowing him a stipend sufficient for only his most pressing needs, hoping that a little hardship would make him wiser.

This garret was perched on the Rue de Lesdiguières, number nine, near the Arsenal, whose library offered its resources to the young laborer. Without a doubt, to pass from an abundant and luxurious house to a miserable hovel would be difficult at any age other than 21, which was the age of Balzac; but if the dream of every child is to have boots, that of every young man is to have a room, a room all to himself, whose key he carries in his pocket, although he can stand upright only at its center: a room, it's the trappings of virility, it's independence, personality, love!

Behold then master Honoré perched near the sky, seated before his table, and trying to create a work that would justify the indulgence of his father and disprove the unfavorable predictions of his friends. It is a remarkable thing that Balzac debuted with a tragedy, with a *Cromwell*! Around that same time, Victor Hugo also put the last touches on his *Cromwell*, whose preface became the manifesto of all young dramatists.

II

In attentively rereading *La Comédie Humaine* when one has known Balzac personally, one finds there scattered curious details with regard to his character and his life, particularly in his first works, where he has not yet separated out his own personality, and, due to a lack of subjects, observes and dissects himself. I have said that he began his rude apprenticeship for the literary life in a garret on the Rue Lesdiguières, near the Arsenal. The novel *Facino Cane*, published in Paris in March, 1836, and dedicated to Louise, contains some precious information regarding the life that this young aspirant for glory led in his aerial nest.

"I lived then in a street which without doubt you do not know, the Rue Lesdiguières: it begins at the Rue Saint-Antoine, opposite a fountain, near the Place de la Bastille, and leads into the Rue de la Cerisaie. The love of science had thrown me into an attic where I wrote all night, and I passed the day in a neighboring library, that of Monsieur; I lived frugally, I had accepted all of the conditions of the monastic life, so necessary for laborers. When the weather was fine, I allowed myself a walk on the Boulevard Bourbon. One sole passion enticed me from my studious habits; but wasn't this also studying? I went to observe the manners of the neighborhood, its inhabitants and their characters. As ill clad as the workers, indifferent to decorum, I did not put them on their guard against me: I could mingle in their groups, see them conclude their deals, and hear them argue about the time that they would stop working. For me, observation had already become intuitive, it penetrated the soul without neglecting the body; in other words it so thoroughly grasped exterior that it transcended it immediately; it gave me the ability to live the life of the individual on which I was focused and permitted me to substitute myself for him, like the dervish of the *Thousand and One Nights* seized the body and the soul of persons over whom he pronounced certain words.

"When, between eleven o'clock and midnight, I met a workman and his wife returning from the Ambigu-Comique, I amused myself by following them from the Boulevard Pont-aux-Choux to the Boulevard Beaumarchais.

These good people would at first speak of the play that they had just seen; next they would address their personal affairs; the mother would pull the child by the hand without listening to either his complaints or his questions. The married couple would count up the money that would be paid to them the next day. They would spend it in twenty different ways. They would then move on to household matters, complaints over the excessive price of potatoes or the length of the winter and the rise in the cost of butter, energetic discussions on how much was owed to the baker, and finally onto discussions where each of them became irritated and demonstrated his character with picturesque words. In listening to these people, I could connect with their life, I felt their rags upon my back, I walked with my feet in their tattered shoes; their desires, their needs, all passed into my soul, and my soul passed into theirs; it was the dream of an awakened man. I became exasperated with them against the workshop foremen who tyrannized them or against the unfair practice that made them return many times without providing them with their pay. To abandon habits, to become another through this intoxication of the moral faculties and to play this game at will, such was my entertainment. To what do I owe this gift? Is it an extrasensory perception? Is it one of those qualities whose abuse would lead to madness? I have never sought the sources of this power; I possess it and I use it, that is all."

I have transcribed these lines, which are doubly interesting because they illuminate a little-known side of Balzac's life, and because they show that he was conscious of this powerful faculty of intuition that he already possessed at such a high level and without which the realization of his work would have been impossible. Balzac, like Vishnu, the Indian god, possessed the gift of metamorphosis, that is to say the ability to incarnate himself into different bodies and live in them as long as he wished; however, the number of the metamorphoses of Vishnu is fixed at ten: those of Balzac are countless, and furthermore he could produce them at will. Although it may seem extravagant to say this in the heart of the nineteenth century, Balzac was a seer. His merits as an observer, his acuteness as a physiologist, his genius as a writer, do not suffice to explain the infinite variety of the two or three thousand types which play a more or less important role in *La Comédie Humaine*. He did not copy them, he lived them in an ideal manner, he wore their clothes, he took on their habits, he immersed himself in their surroundings, he was them for as long as necessary. From there come these authentic, logical characters, never contradicting themselves and never forgetting themselves, endowed with an intimate and profound existence, who, to use one of his expressions, took on the challenge of life in civil

society. Truly red blood circulated in their veins in place of the ink that infused the creations of ordinary writers.

Balzac did not possess this ability for any time except the present. He could transport his thought into a marquis, into a financier, into a middle-class person, into a man of the people, into a woman of the world, into a courtesan, but the shadows of the past did not obey his call: he never knew, like Goethe, how to evoke from the depths of antiquity the beautiful Hélène and make her dwell in the Gothic manor of Faust. With two or three exceptions, all of his work is modern; he has assimilated the living, he has not resurrected the dead. Even history seduced him little, as one can see from the preface to *La Comédie Humaine*: "In reading the dry and off-putting catalogues of facts called *histories*, who has not recognized that the writers have forgotten in every era, in Egypt, in Persia, in Greece, in Rome, to give us the history of manners? The piece by Petronius on the private life of the Romans irritates rather than satisfies our curiosity."

This void left by the historians of vanished societies, Balzac proposed to fill for our own, and God knows that he carefully followed the program that he had planned.

"Society was going to be the historian, I should not be but the secretary; in constructing the inventory of vices and of virtues, in assembling the principal features of the passions, in depicting the characters, in choosing the principal events of the society, in composing types by the blending of traits of several homogeneous characters, perhaps I could succeed in writing the history forgotten by so many historians, that of manners. With a great deal of patience and courage, I might be able to complete, on nineteenth century France, the book that we all regret that Rome, Athens, Tyre, Memphis, Persia, India, have unfortunately not left us on their civilization, and that like the abbot Bartholomew, the courageous and patient Monteil had attempted regarding the Middle Ages, although in a form that was not appealing."

But let us return to the garret on the Rue Lesdiguières. Balzac had not conceived the plan of the work that would immortalize him; he was still seeking it with anxiety, bated breath, and hard labor, trying everything and succeeding in nothing; however he already possessed that obstinacy in his work to which Minerva, as surly as she might be, must one day or another yield; he outlined comic operas, made plans for comedies, dramas and romances whose titles Madame de Surville has preserved: *Stella*, *Cosigrue*, *Les Deux Philosophes*, without counting the terrible *Cromwell*, whose verses had caused him so much pain and yet were not worth much more than that which began his epic poem, *Incas*.

Imagine to yourself young Honoré, his legs wrapped in a patched coat, his upper body protected by an old shawl of his mother, his head a sort of Dantesque cap and his hair of a cut that only Madame de Balzac knew, his coffee pot to his left, his inkwell to his right, working with a heaving chest and bowed forehead, like an ox at the plow, the field still stony and not cleared by those thoughts which would later trace for him such productive furrows. The lamp shines like a star in the front of the dark house, the snow falls in silence on the loosened tiles, the wind blows through the door and window "like Tulou on his Flute, but less agreeably."

If some dawdling passerby had raised his eyes toward that little, obstinately flickering glow, he certainly would not have suspected that it was the dawning of one of the greatest glories of our age.

Would you like to see a sketch of the place, transposed, it's true, but very exact, drawn by the author in *La Peau de Chagrin*, that work which contains so much of himself?

"... A room which looks down upon the yards of the neighboring houses, from the windows of which extend long poles hung with washing; nothing was more horrible than that garret with those yellow, grimy walls, which soaked in the misery and called out to its scholar. The roof slanted in a uniform fashion, and the loosened tiles permitted a view of the sky; there was room for a bed, a table, a few chairs, and under the sharp angle of the roof I could position my piano ... I lived in this aerial sepulcher for almost three years, working night and day, without rest, with so much pleasure that my studies seemed to be the most beautiful focus, the happiest solution to human life. The calm and silence necessary to the scholar have some elements of the sweetness and intoxication of love ... Study lends a sort of magic to everything that surrounds us. The meager desk upon which I wrote and the brown leather that covered it, my piano, my bed, my armchair, the peculiar wallpaper, my furniture, all of these things came to life and became for me humble friends, silent partners in my future. How many times have I not shared my soul while gazing upon them? Often, while letting my eyes wander on a crooked molding, I would encounter new developments, a striking proof of my system that I believed was able to convey nearly untranslatable thoughts."

In this same passage, he makes an allusion to his work: "I had undertaken two great works; a comedy that was in only a few days to give me fame, a fortune and entry into that world in which I wanted to reappear while exercising the kingly rights of a man of genius. You have all seen in this masterpiece the first error of a young man just out of college, the

nonsense of a child. Your jibes destroyed the nascent illusions, which since then have not been awakened ..."

One recognizes here the ill-fated *Cromwell*, which, read in front of the family and the assembled friends, was a complete fiasco.

Honoré appealed this sentence before an arbiter whom he accepted as competent, an honorable old man, a former professor at the École Polytechnique. The judgment was that the author should do "anything at all, except literature."

What a loss for letters, what a void in the human spirit if the young man had bowed before the experience of the old man and listened to his counsel, which, certainly, was most wise, because there was not the least spark of genius nor even of talent in this rhetorical tragedy! Happily Balzac, under the pseudonym of Louis Lambert, had not composed for nothing at the college of Vendôme the *Traité de la Volonté*.

He submitted to the sentence, but only for tragedy; he understood that he should give up trying to walk in the footsteps of Corneille and Racine, whom he so admired without being in their debt, for never were geniuses more contrary to that of himself. The novel offered him a more suitable model, and he wrote at this time a great number of volumes which he did not sign and which he always disavowed. The Balzac that we know and that we admire was still in limbo and struggled in vain to extricate himself. Those who had judged him capable of being nothing but a copyist appeared to be right; perhaps even this option had failed him, because his beautiful handwriting had already deteriorated with the crumpled, crossed out, overwritten, near hieroglyphic drafts of the writer fighting for the idea and no longer concerned about the beauty of the character.

Thus, nothing resulted from this rigorous confinement, this hermetic life in the Thébaidé in which Raphaël outlines the budget: "Three sous of bread, two sous of milk, three sous of meat that prevented me from dying of hunger and kept my mind in a state of singular lucidity. My lodgings cost me three sous a day; I burned three sous of oil every night, I took care of my own room, I wore flannel shirts so that I would spend only two sous a day for laundry. I warmed myself with coal, whose price divided by the days in the year never gave more than two sous for each. I had suits of clothes, linens, and shoes for three years: I didn't want to get dressed except to go to certain public lectures and to the libraries; these expenses combined were only eighteen sous: there remained two sous for unforeseen things. I do not recall having, during this long period of work, having passed the Pont des Arts or ever buying water."

Without doubt, Raphaël exaggerated these economies a little, but Balzac's correspondence with his sister shows that the novel does not differ much from the reality. The old woman referred to in his letters by the name of Iris la Messagère, who was 70 years old, could not have been a very active housekeeper, as Balzac writes: "The news of my household is disastrous, the work does harm to its cleanliness. This rascal of *Myself* neglects himself more and more, he only descends every three or four days to make some purchases, he goes to the closest and worst provisioned merchants in the quarter: the others are too far, and the fellow economizes even his steps; so that your brother (destined for so much celebrity) is already nourished absolutely like a great man, that is to say that he is dying of hunger."

"Another problem: The coffee is made terribly bitter by dirt. Lots of water is needed to correct the damage; but the water does not rise to my celestial garret (it descends there only on stormy days), it will require, after the purchase of the piano, the installation of a hydraulic machine, if the coffee continues to disappear while the master and the servant daydream."

Elsewhere, continuing the joking, he reprimands the lazy *Myself*, the only footman that he has in his service, who does not fill the basin, leaves dust balls scattered freely under the bed, the dirt obscuring the windows, and the spiders spinning their webs in the corners.

In another letter, he writes: "I have eaten two melons ... it will be necessary to pay for them with nuts and dry bread!"

One of the rare recreations that he permitted himself was to go to the Jardin des Plantes or Père-Lachaise. At the summit of the funereal hill, he towered over Paris like Rastignac at the burial of Père Goriot. His gaze glided over this ocean of slate and tile that cover up so much luxury, misery, intrigue and passion. Like a young eagle, he took in his prey at a glance; but he still had no wings, no beak, no talons, although his eye could already fix itself on the sun. He said, contemplating the tombs: "There are no more beautiful epitaphs than these: La Fontaine, Masséna, Molière: one single name that says everything and makes us dream!"

This sentence contains an ill-defined but prophetic understanding that the future realized, alas!, too soon. On the slope of the hill, upon a sepulchral stone, beneath a bust cast in bronze, after the marble of David, the word BALZAC says everything and makes the solitary wanderer dream.

The dietary regimen recommended by Raphaël could be favorable to the lucidity of the brain; but certainly it was worthless for a young man used to the comfort of family life. The fifteen months that passed under these intellectual burdens, sadder, without fail, than those of Venice, had made the

youthful Tourangeau with the soft, glowing cheeks a Parisian skeleton, haggard and yellow, nearly unrecognizable. Balzac reentered the paternal home, where the fatted calf was killed for the return of this only slightly prodigal child.

I glide lightly over the period of his life when he tried to ensure independence by speculations in the book trade and during which only a lack of capital prevented him from finding success. These ventures put him in debt, mortgaged his future, and despite the devoted assistance offered perhaps too late by the family, burdened him with the rock of Sisyphus that he so many times pushed just to the edge of the hill, and which always fell back with more crushing weight upon the shoulders of this Atlas, overloaded besides by an entire world.

This debt that he made it a sacred duty to discharge, because it represented the fortune of those who were dear to him, was Necessity armed with a spiked whip, her hand bearing bronze nails that harassed him night and day, with neither truce nor pity, making him regard every hour of repose or recreation as a theft. She dominated his entire life painfully, often rendering it inexplicable to he who did not possess its secret.

Having provided these indispensable biographical details, I come to my direct and personal impressions of Balzac.

Balzac, that immense brain, that physiologist so penetrating, that observer so profound, that mind so intuitive, did not possess the literary gift: within him there opened an abyss between the thought and the form. That abyss, particularly in the early years, he despaired of crossing. He threw himself without fulfillment into volume upon volume, observation upon observation, essay upon essay; an entire library of disavowed books passed through there. A will less robust would have been discouraged a thousand times; but happily Balzac had an unshakeable confidence in his genius, unknown to all the world. He wanted to be a great man, and he was that by his unrelenting projections of that force that was more powerful than electricity, and with which he made such subtle analyses in *Louis Lambert*.

Unlike the writers of the romantic school, who distinguished themselves by a boldness and astonishing facility of execution, and produced their fruits at nearly the same time as their flowers, in a blossoming that was in a sense involuntary, Balzac, the equal in genius of them all, did not find his means of expression, or did not find it until after infinite suffering. Hugo said in one of his prefaces, with his Castilian pride: "I do not know the art of soldering a beauty in the place of a defect, and I correct myself in another work." But Balzac would cover a tenth proof with his crossings out, and when he saw me return to the *La Chronique de Paris*

the proof of an article written in a hurry, on the corner of a table, with only typographical corrections, he could not believe, as content as he was otherwise, that I had applied all of my talent there. "By reworking it two or three times, it would have been better," he said to me.

Citing himself as an example, he preached to me a strange literary lifestyle. I must cloister myself for two or three years, drink water, eat soggy lupins like Protogène, go to bed at six o'clock in the evening, get up at midnight, and work until morning, using the day to revise, expand, shorten, perfect, polish the nocturnal work, correct the proofs, take notes, do the necessary studies, and live most importantly with absolute chastity. He insisted a great deal upon this last recommendation, which was very challenging for a young man of twenty-four or twenty-five years. According to him, true chastity develops to the highest degree the powers of the mind, and gives to those who practice it unidentified abilities. I timidly objected that the greatest geniuses did not forbid themselves love, passion, or even pleasure, and I cited some illustrious names. Balzac shook his head and responded, "They would have done better, without the women!"

The only concession that he would grant me, and even then he regretted it, was to see my beloved one half hour each year. He permitted letters: "These guide the development of style."

By means of this regimen, he promised to make of me, with the natural abilities that he was pleased to recognize in me, a writer of the first order. It is clear from my work that I have not followed this plan.

It must not be believed that Balzac was joking when he laid down these conditions that the Trappists or the Carthusians would have found harsh. He was perfectly convinced, and spoke with such eloquence that many times I consciously tried to use this method to develop genius; I awoke numerous times at midnight, and after having partaken of the inspirational coffee, acted according to the formula, seating myself in front of a table on which sleep caused me to quickly lay my head. *La Morte Amoureuse*, published in the *La Chronique de Paris*, was my only nocturnal work.

Around this time, Balzac had written for a review *Facino Cane*, the story of a noble Venetian who, imprisoned in the vaults of the ducal palace, had fallen, while digging an escape tunnel, upon the secret treasure of the Republic, a good part of which he carried away with the help of a bribed jailer. Facino Cane, who became blind and played the clarinet under the common name of Father Canet, had kept an extrasensory perception for gold; he recognized it through walls and in vaults, and he offered to the writer, at a wedding in the Faubourg Saint-Antoine, to guide him, if he was willing to pay him the cost of the journey, toward this immense mass of

riches whose location had been lost due to the fall of the Venetian Republic. Balzac, as I have said, lived his characters, and at this moment, he was Facino Cane himself, although without the blindness, for never have there been eyes more sparkling or scintillating on a human face. He dreamed of nothing but tons of gold, heaps of diamonds and garnets, and, by means of magnetism, with whose practices he had been long familiar, he sought from these explorations the location of the buried and lost treasure. He pretended to have learned in this way, in the most precise manner, the place where, near the hill of Pointe-à-Pître, Toussaint Louverture had caused his booty to be buried by negroes who were immediately shot. *The Gold-Bug*, of Edgar Poe, does not equal, in subtlety of reasoning, in clarity of plan, in divination of details, the fevered rendition that he has given us of the expedition to attempt to become master of this treasure, which was far richer than that which was buried by Tom Kidd at the skull at the foot of the Talipot.

I implore the reader to not make too much fun of me, if I confess to him in all humility that I soon shared the conviction of Balzac. What brain could have resisted his breathtaking speech? Jules Sandeau was also soon seduced, and as he needed two dependable friends, two devoted and robust companions to perform the nocturnal excavations under the direction of the seer, Balzac was pleased to grant us one-fourth each of this prodigious fortune. One-half was to revert to him by right, as he had made the discovery and directed the enterprise.

We were to buy pikes, pickaxes and shovels, get them secretly on board the vessel, and get ourselves to a designated point by different routes so as not to excite suspicions, and, the blow being struck, we were to transport our riches on a brigantine chartered in advance; in short, it was quite a tale, which would have been admirable if Balzac had written it instead of speaking it.

There is no need to say that we did not unearth the treasure of Toussaint Louverture. Money was not available to pay our passage; the three of us had at most enough to buy the pickaxes.

The dream of a sudden fortune won by some strange and marvelous means often haunted the brain of Balzac; some years before (in 1833), he had made a voyage to Sardinia to examine the slag of the silver mines abandoned by the Romans, which, treated by imperfect processes, must according to him still have contained a great deal of metal. The idea was reasonable and, imprudently confided, made the fortune of another.

I have related the anecdote of the treasure buried by Toussaint Louverture, not for the pleasure of telling a strange story, but because it is connected with a dominant idea of Balzac – money. Certainly, nobody was less avaricious than the author of *La Comédie Humaine*, but his genius made him foresee the immense role that this metallic hero would play in art, more interesting for modern society than the Grandissons, the Desgrieux, the Oswalds, the Werthers, the Malek-Adhels, the Renés, the Laras, the Waverleys, the Quentin Durwards, etc.

Until then the story had been confined to the portrayal of a unique passion, love, but love in an ideal sphere and outside of the necessities and miseries of life. The personages of these entirely psychological recitals neither ate, nor drank, nor lodged, nor had an account with their tailor. They moved in an abstract environment like those of a tragedy. If they wished to travel, they put, without obtaining a passport, some handfuls of diamonds into the bottom of their pocket, and paid with this currency the postilions, who did not fail at each way station to have exhausted their horses; some chateaus of indistinct architecture received them at the end of their journeys, and with their blood they wrote to their beloveds interminable epistles dated from the tour of the North. The heroines, no less immaterial, resembled an aquatint of Angelica Kauffmann: a large straw hat, hair somewhat straightened in the English style, a long robe of white chiffon, held at the waist by an azure sash.

With his profound instinct for reality, Balzac understood that the modern life he wanted to portray was dominated by one grand fact, money, and, in *La Peau de Chagrin*, he had the courage to present a lover not only anxious to know if he had touched the heart of the one he loves, but also if he will have enough money to pay for the carriage in which he was bringing her home. This audacity is perhaps one of the greatest that one might permit oneself in literature, and it alone sufficed to immortalize Balzac. The consternation was profound, and the purists were indignant at this infraction of the laws of the genre; but all the young people who, going out in the evening to the home of some beautiful woman wearing white gloves ironed with gum elastic, had traversed Paris as dancers, on the tips of their shoes, fearing a spot of mud more than the crack of a pistol, commiserated, having shared these fears, like the anguishes of Valentin, who cared deeply about a hat that he could not renew and preserve despite his minute care. In moments of supreme misery, the discovery of a one hundred sou piece slid under the papers of the drawer, due to the discreet pity of Pauline, produced the effect of the most romantic theatrical strokes or of the intervention of a Peri in the Arabian tales. Who has not discovered during days of distress,

forgotten in pants or in a vest, a few glorious coins appearing at just the right time and saving you from the calamity that youth fears the most: to fail to provide a beloved woman with a carriage, a bouquet, a small bench, a show program, a tip to the usherette or some trifles of this type?

Balzac excels in the portrayal of youth who are poor, as they almost always are, entering into their first struggles with life, prey to the temptation of pleasures and luxury, and experiencing profound miseries due to their high hopes. Valentin, Rastignac, Bianchon, d'Arthez, Lucien de Rubempré, Lousteau, have all sunk their beautiful teeth into the tough meat of the angry cow, fortifying food for robust stomachs, indigestible for weak stomachs; he does not lodge them, these beautiful young ones without a sou, in conventional garrets decorated with Persian rugs, with windows festooned with sweet peas and looking out on gardens; he does not have them eat "some simple dishes, prepared by the hand of nature," and does not dress them in luxurious garments, but in those that are proper and practical; he puts them in the boarding house of Mother Vauquer, or forces them to crouch under the sharp angle of a roof, he presses them into greasy tables at mean little restaurants, dressing them in black clothing with gray seams, and he is not afraid to send them to the pawn shop, if they still have, a rare occurrence, their father's watch.

Oh Corinne, you who allows, upon Cape Misèna, your snowy arm to dangle across your ivory lyre, while the son of Albion, draped in a superb new coat, and shod in his beloved perfectly polished boots, reflects on you and listens to you in an elegant pose, Corinne, what would you have said to such heroes? They have however one small quality that was lacking in Oswald, they live, and of a life so robust that it seems like one has encountered them one thousand times; also Pauline, Delphine de Nucingen, the princess of Cadignan, Madame de Bargeton, Coralie, Esther, are madly infatuated with them.

At the time that the first novels signed by Balzac appeared, one did not have, to the same degree as today, the preoccupation, or, better said, the fever for gold. California had not been discovered; there existed perhaps several leagues of railway whose future one hardly suspected, and that one saw as a kind of conduit that led up to the Russian mountains, but that had fallen into disuse; the public ignored, so to speak, "business," and only bankers gambled at the Bourse. This movement of capital, this flow of gold, these calculations, these figures, this importance given to money in works that one still took as simple romantic fictions and not as serious portraits of life, singularly shocked the subscribers to the reading rooms, and critics added up the total sums spent or staked by the author. The millions of father

Grandet led to arithmetic discussions, and serious people, troubled by the enormity of the totals, doubted the financial abilities of Balzac, very great abilities nevertheless, and recognized later. Stendhal said with a sort of disdainful smugness, "Before writing, I always read three or four pages of the Civil Code to give me the tone." Balzac, who understood money so well, also discovered poems and dramas in the Code: *Le Contrat de Mariage*, where he places in opposition, in the persons of Matthias and of Solonnet, the ancient and the modern notary, has all of the interest of the most eventful comedy of the cloak and sword. The bankruptcy in *Grandeur et Décadence de César Birotteau* makes you quiver like the story of an empire's fall; the conflict of the château and the cottage in *Les Paysans* offers just as much adventure as the siege of Troy. Balzac knows how to give life to the soil, to a house, to a heritage, to a capital, and in fact to heroes and heroines whose adventures are devoured with anxious avidity.

These new elements introduced into the novel were not appreciated at first; the philosophical analyses, the detailed character portraits, the minute descriptions that seemed to have the future in view, were regarded as unpleasantly lengthy, and quite often one skipped them to move on to the story. Later, one recognized that the goal of the author was not to weave intrigues that were more or less well-plotted, but to portray society in its entirety, from the summit to the base, with its characters and its components, and that one will admire in it the immense variety of these types. Is it not Alexandre Dumas who said of Shakespeare: "Shakespeare, the man who has created the most after God?"; the words might be even more justly applied to Balzac; never, indeed, did so many living creatures issue from one human brain.

At this time (1836), Balzac had conceived the plan for his *Comédie Humaine* and possessed the full awareness of his genius. He adroitly connected the works that had already been published to his general concept and found them a place in the categories that had been philosophically outlined. Some novels of pure fantasy did not fit in very well, despite the connections that were added afterwards; but these are details that are lost in the immensity of the ensemble, like ornaments in a differing style on a grand edifice.

I have said that Balzac worked laboriously, and, being an obstinate smelter, rejected ten or twelve times from the crucible the metal that had not perfectly filled the mold; like Bernard Palissy, he would have burned the furniture, the flooring and up through the beams of his house without regret to maintain the fire in his furnace; the most challenging necessities would never make him deliver a work on which he had not put the utmost effort,

and he gave admirable examples of literary conscientiousness. His corrections, so numerous that they were almost equivalent to different editions on the same idea, were charged to his account by the editors who were responsible for earnings, and his compensation, often modest for the value of the work and the pain it had cost him, were diminished in proportion. The promised sums did not always arrive on time, and to sustain what he laughingly called his floating debt, Balzac displayed prodigious resources of mind and a level of activity that would have completely absorbed the life of an ordinary man. But, when seated before his table in his friar's frock, in the midst of the nocturnal silence, he found himself confronted with blank sheets illuminated by the glow of seven candles, concentrated by a green shade, in taking pen in hand he forgot everything, and thus commenced a struggle more terrible than the conflict of Jacob with the angel, that of form and idea. In these nightly battles, from which in the morning he would issue broken but victorious, when the extinguished hearth chilled the atmosphere of his room once again, his head steamed and his body exhaled a visible fog like the body of a horse in wintertime. Sometimes only a single phrase occupied an entire evening; it was considered, reconsidered, twisted, kneaded, pounded, stretched, shortened, written in one hundred different ways, and, bizarrely, the necessary, complete, form, would not present itself until after the exhaustion of the approximate forms; without doubt the metal often flowed from a fuller and thicker hose, but there are very few pages in Balzac that stayed identical to the first draft. His manner of proceeding was this: when he had for a long time borne and lived a subject, with writing that was rapid, jumbled, blotted, nearly hieroglyphic, he would outline a sort of scenario in a few pages, which he would send to the printer and which was returned on placards, that is to say as isolated columns in the middle of large sheets. He read these placards carefully, which already gave to his embryo of work that impersonal character that the manuscript does not have, and he applied to this rough sketch the high critical faculty that he possessed, acting as if he were another person. He worked on something; approving or disapproving, he kept or corrected, but mostly added. Lines issuing from the beginning, the middle or the end of phrases, were directed toward the margins, to the right, to the left, to the top, to the bottom, leading to some developments, to insertions, to interpolations, to epithets, to adverbs. At the end of some hours of work, one would have called his sheet a bouquet of fireworks drawn by a child. From the primitive text shot forth rockets of style which exploded on all sides. Then there were simple crosses, crosses recrossed like a coat of arms, stars, suns, Arab or Roman numerals, Greek or French

letters, every imaginable sign of reference to mix with the scratchings. Some strips of paper, fastened with sealing wafers, stuck on with pins, added to the insufficient margins, striped with lines of fine characters to conserve space, themselves full of crossings out, because the correction that had barely been made had itself already been corrected. The printed placard nearly disappeared in what appeared to be a cabalistic book of spells, which the typographers passed from hand to hand, each not wanting to work for more than an hour on Balzac.

The following day, they sent back the placards with the corrections made, and already expanded by half.

Balzac resumed work, always amplifying, adding a trait, a detail, a description, an observation on manners, a characteristic word, a phrase for effect, bringing the form closer to the idea, always moving closer to his internal outline, choosing like a painter among three or four contours the definitive line. Often this terrible work ended with that intensity of attention of which he alone was capable, as he recognized that a thought had been poorly expressed, that one incident predominated, that a figure that he wished to be secondary for general effect deviated from his plan, and with one stroke of the pen he would courageously destroy the result of four or five nights of labor. He was heroic in these circumstances.

Six, seven, and sometimes ten proofs were returned with crossings out, rewritten, without satisfying the author's desire for perfection. I have seen at Les Jardies, on the shelves of a library composed of only his works, each different proof of the same work bound in a separate volume from the first sketch to the definitive book; the comparison of Balzac's thought at these diverse stages offers a very curious study and contains profitable literary lessons. Near these volumes a sinister looking book, bound in black morocco leather, with neither clasps nor gilding, drew my attention: "Take it," Balzac said to me, "it is an unpublished work which may have some value." Its title was *Comptes Mélancoliques*; it contained lists of debts, due dates of bills to be paid, notices of purveyors and all that menacing paperwork that is legalized by a stamp. This volume, with a kind of mocking contrast, was placed beside the *Contes Drolatiques*, "of which it is not a continuation," added the author of *La Comédie Humaine* with a laugh.

Despite this laborious method of execution, Balzac produced a great deal, thanks to his superhuman will supplemented by the temperament of an athlete and the seclusion of a monk. For two or three months in succession, when he had some important work in progress, he labored sixteen or eighteen hours out of twenty-four; he granted to his animal being only six hours of a heavy, feverish, convulsive sleep, encouraged by the torpor of

digestion after a hastily taken meal. He would disappear so completely, his best friends would lose all trace; but he would soon return from underground, waving a major work above his head, laughing his hearty laugh, applauding himself with a perfect innocence and according himself the praise that he demanded from no one else. No author was more unconcerned than him regarding reviews and advertising upon the release of his books; he allowed his reputation to grow by itself, without putting his hand to it, and he never courted journalists. Indeed other things consumed his time: he delivered his copy, took his money and fled to distribute it to his creditors who often waited in the journal's courtyard, like, for example, the masons of Les Jardies.

Sometimes, in the morning, he would meet me breathless, exhausted, giddy from the fresh air, like Vulcan escaping from his forge, and he would fall upon a couch; his long vigil had left him starving and he would blend sardines with butter and make a sort of paste which reminded him of the rillettes of Tours, and which he would spread on bread. This was his favorite dish; he had no sooner eaten than he fell asleep, begging me to awaken him after one hour. Without regard for his admonition, I would respect this well-earned sleep, and I silenced all of the whispers in the house. When Balzac awoke of his own accord, and he saw that the evening's twilight was diffusing its gray tints across the sky, he would leap up from his couch and heap me with abuse, calling me traitor, thief, assassin: I made him lose ten thousand francs, because awake he could have had the idea for a novel that would have earned this sum (without the reprints). I was the cause of the gravest catastrophes and unimaginable disorders. I had made him miss meetings with bankers, editors, duchesses; he would not be able to repay his debts on time; this fatal sleep would cost millions. But I was already used to these prodigious betting systems that Balzac, starting from the lowest figure, would push excessively to the most monstrous sums, and I easily consoled myself by seeing the beautiful colors characteristic in Tours reappear on his rested cheeks.

Balzac lived then at Chaillot, rue des Batailles, a house from which one found an admirable view of the course of the Seine, the Champ de Mars, the École Militaire, the dome of the Invalides, a large proportion of Paris and further away the hills of Meudon. He had arranged there an interior that was luxurious enough, because he knew that in Paris nobody believed in an impoverished talent, and that *perception* often leads to *reality*. It was during this period that one hears of his tendencies toward elegance and dandyism, the famous blue coat with solid gold buttons, the walking stick with a turquoise head, the appearances at the Bouffes and at the Opera, and the

more frequent visits into society where his sparkling flair made him much sought after, visits that were useful for more than one reason, for he met there more than one model. It was not easy to penetrate into his home, which was better guarded than the garden of the Hespérides. Two or three passwords were required. Balzac, for fear they might be divulged, changed them often. I remember these ones: to the porter one said: "Prune season has arrived," and he would let you cross the threshold; to the servant who ran to the stairs at the sound of the bell, it was necessary to whisper: "I bring lace from Belgium," and if you could assure the bedroom valet that "Madame Bertrand was in good health," you were finally introduced.

This childish behavior very much amused Balzac; it was necessary to ward off unwanted people and those who were even more disagreeable.

In *La Fille aux Yeux d'Or* is found a description of the salon in the rue des Batailles. It is of the most scrupulous fidelity, and one will not be displeased to see the lion's den painted by himself. There is not a detail to add or to subtract.

"Half of the sitting room described a delicately graceful circular line, opposite of which the other half was perfectly square, in the middle of which shined a fireplace of white marble and gold. One entered through a side door concealed by a rich tapestry and which faced a window. The horseshoe-shaped section of the room was decorated with a real Turkish divan, that is to say with a mattress placed on the ground, but a mattress as large as a bed, a divan fifty feet in circumference covered in white cashmere, embellished with tufts of black and poppy-colored silk, arranged in a diamond pattern; the back of this immense bed was elevated several inches higher by the numerous cushions that enriched it further by their stylish compatibility. This sitting room was hung with a red fabric on which was mounted a muslin from the Indies that was fluted like a Corinthian column by piping that alternated between hollow and round and stopped at the top and bottom with a band of poppy-colored fabric, on which were drawn some black arabesques. Under the muslin, the poppy color became rose, an amorous color that repeated in the window curtains, which were of muslin from the Indies lined with rose-colored taffeta and ornamented with poppy and black fringes. Six silver arms each supporting two candles were attached to these wall coverings at equal distances, to illuminate the divan. The ceiling, from the center of which hung a lantern of matte silver, sparkled with whiteness, and the molding was gilded. The carpet resembled an Oriental shawl, it presented the designs and recalled the poetry of Persia, where the hands of slaves had created it. The furniture was covered in white cashmere, set off by black and poppy-colored accents. The clock, the

candelabras, all were of white marble and gold. The only table in the room had a cashmere covering; elegant jardinières contained roses of every type, and white or red flowers."

I can add that upon the table was placed a magnificent writing desk in gold and malachite, the gift, without a doubt, of some admiring stranger.

It was with a childlike satisfaction that Balzac showed me this sitting room set in a square salon, and by necessity leaving empty spaces at the angles of the circular half. When I had admired the stylish splendors of this room sufficiently, splendors whose luxury would seem less today, Balzac opened a secret door and made me enter a shadowy passage that led around the semicircle; at one of the corners was placed a narrow iron bed, a kind of working camp bed; in the other, there was a table "with everything that is necessary to write," as M. Scribe said in his stage directions: it was there that Balzac took refuge to be free of all intrusions and all investigations.

Many thicknesses of fabric and paper padded the wall to block all noise from both sides. To be sure that no sounds could pass into the salon from outside, Balzac asked me to return to the room and shout as loudly as I could; one could still hear a little; it was necessary to add a few sheets of gray paper to entirely block the sound. These mysterious actions intrigued me immensely and I demanded to know their motivation. Balzac gave me a reason that Stendhal would have approved, but modern prudery prevents my repeating. The fact is that he was already developing in his mind the scene of Henry de Marsay and Paquita, and he was anxious to know if the cries of the victim in the salon could reach the ears of the other inhabitants of the house.

He gave me a splendid dinner in the same sitting room, for which he lit with his own hand all of the candles on the silver arms, as well as the lantern and the candelabras. The guests were the Marquis de B. and the painter L. B.: although very sober and abstemious by habit, Balzac from time to time did not fear to "indulge in a little good cheer"; he ate with a jovial gourmandism that inspired the appetite, and he drank in the manner of Pantagruel. Four bottles of the white wine of Vouvray, one of the headiest known, did not affect his powerful brain and gave only a greater sparkle to his gaiety. What good stories he told us at dessert! Rabelais, Beroalde de Verville, Eutrapel, le Pogge, Straparole, the Queen of Navarre and all of the doctors of the happy science would have recognized in him a disciple and a master!

Characteristic feature! At this splendid feast provided by Chevet there was no bread! But when one has excess then what is the point of necessities?

After dinner, our Amphytrion led us to the Italians in a superb presentation. The evening was already getting late, but Balzac did not want to miss "the descent of the staircase" spectacle, which, according to him, was eminently instructive.

Weighed down by the good food and fine wines, enveloped in the warm atmosphere of the room, I should say that the three of us slept the sleep of the just and only awakened to offer our final compliments.

Balzac was quite amused by this somnolent trio.

In the same apartment on the rue des Batailles, whose salon I described using Balzac's own words, I recall having seen a magnificent sketch of Louis Boulanger after a bas-relief of *Léda and the Swan* attributed to Michelangelo. It was the only picture that it contained, because the author of *La Comédie Humaine* did not yet have the taste for paintings and curiosities that he would later develop, and his luxury then, as we have seen, consisted more of sumptuousness than of art. His painter was Girodet. Some of his first stories show the influence of this admiration which led me to tease him with jibes that he accepted with good grace.

IV

One of the dreams of Balzac was of a heroic and devoted friendship, two souls, two courages, two intelligences blended into the same will. Pierre and Jaffier of Otway's *Venice Preserv'd* had impressed him greatly and he spoke of them many times. *L'Histoire des Treize* is nothing but this idea enlarged and complicated: one powerful unit composed of multiple beings acting unquestioningly toward an accepted and suitable goal. We know what gripping, mysterious and terrible effects he has drawn from this starting point in *Ferragus*, *La Duchesse de Langeais*, and *La Fille aux Yeux d'Or*; but real life and the intellectual life were not as clearly separated for Balzac as they were for certain authors, and his creations followed him outside of his study. He wanted to form an association after the fashion of that which united Ferragus, Montriveau, Ronquerolles, and their companions. Only it was not done in such bold strokes; a certain number of friends were to lend each other aid and relief at all times, and to work according to their strengths for the success or the fortune of the individual who would be selected, with the understanding that that person should in turn work for the others. Very much infatuated with his project, Balzac recruited some associates whom he put in contact with each other but took precautions as if it were a political society or a meeting of Carbonari. This needless mystery amused him considerably, and he pursued his activities

with the utmost seriousness. When their numbers were complete, he assembled the adepts and made known the goal of the society. It need not be said that everyone was in agreement, and that the statutes were approved with enthusiasm. No one more than Balzac possessed the ability to agitate, to overexcite, to intoxicate the coolest heads, the most considered intellects. He had an eloquence that was overflowing, tumultuous, rousing, that carried you off: no objection was possible with him; he would immediately drown you in such a deluge of words that you were compelled to be silent. Besides he had an answer for everything; then he would cast upon you glances that were so sharp, so brilliant, so full of a mysterious power that he would infuse you with his own desire.

The association which counted among its members G. de C., L. G., L. D., J. S., Merle, who was called Handsome Merle, myself, and a few others who it is not necessary to name, was called *Le Cheval Rouge*. Why *Le Cheval Rouge*, you are going to say, rather than *Le Lion d'Or* or *La Croix de Malte*? The first meeting of the members took place at a restaurant on the Quai de l'Entrepôt, at the end of the Pont de la Tournelle, whose sign was a carrier's horse, and this had given Balzac the idea of that somewhat bizarre, unintelligible, and cabalistic designation.

When it was necessary to organize a project, to agree on certain steps, Balzac, elected by acclamation grandmaster of the order, sent by one of the members to each horse (that was the slang name used by the members among themselves) a letter on which was drawn a small red horse with the words: "Stable, at such and such a day, at such and such a location"; the place changed each time, out of fear of awakening curiosity or suspicion. In the society, although we all knew each other and for a long time for the most part, we were to avoid speaking to each other or approaching each other except in the most distant manner to avoid any idea of complicity. Often, in the middle of a salon, Balzac would pretend to meet me for the first time, and by blinks of the eye and facial expressions such as actors make in their asides, he would call my attention to his finesse and seem to say to me: "See how well I play my game!"

What was the goal of *Le Cheval Rouge*? Did it wish to change the government, set forth a new religion, found a philosophical school, master men, seduce women? Far less than that. It sought to take control of the newspapers, take control of the theatres, sit in the seats of the Academy, receive an array of decorations, and end modestly as a peer of France, minister and millionaire. All this was easy, according to Balzac; we had only to work in harmony with each other, and by such modest ambition we should prove well the moderation of our characters. This devil of a man had

such a powerful vision that he described to each of us, in the most minute details, the splendid and glorious life that the association would procure for us. As we listened to him, we believed ourselves already leaning, at the heart of a beautiful mansion, against the white marble of the fireplace, red ribbons around our necks, a shining badge over our hearts, receiving with an affable air the greatest politicians, artists and writers, who were shocked by our rapid and mysterious fortune. For Balzac, the future did not exist, everything was in the present; he drew it out of the mists and made it palpable; an idea was so vivid that it became real in a certain way: in speaking of a dinner, he ate it as he told its story; of a carriage, he felt the soft cushions under him and the steady ride; a perfect well-being, a profound jubilation were then shown on his face, although often he was hungry and walking over a rough pavement with worn-out shoes.

The whole association would push, praise, and extol, by articles, advertisements and conversations, any one of its members who had just published a book or staged a drama. Whoever showed himself to be hostile to one of the horses would provoke the kicks of the entire stable; *Le Cheval Rouge* would not forgive: the culpable became the target of insults, cutting remarks, pin pricks, taunts and other means of driving a man to despair, which are well known by the smaller newspapers.

I smile while betraying after so many years the innocent secret of this literary freemasonry, which had no other result than some persuasive words for a book whose success did not require them. But, at that time, we took the thing seriously, we imagined ourselves to be the *Treize* themselves in person, and I was surprised to find that obstacles still existed; but the world is so badly designed! What an important and mysterious air we had in challenging other men, poor conventional men who in no way doubted our power.

After four or five meetings, *Le Cheval Rouge* ceased to exist; most of the horses could not afford to pay for their oats in this symbolic manger, and the association which was going to seize total control was dissolved, because its members often lacked the fifteen francs to pay their share. Each one now dove back alone into the chaos of life, fighting his own fight, and it is this that explains why Balzac was not a member of the Academy and died a simple knight of the Legion of Honor.

The idea however was good, for Balzac, as he himself says of Nucingen, could not have a bad idea. Others who have succeeded have set to work without surrounding themselves with the same romantic fantasies.

Thrown off of one chimera, Balzac very quickly mounted a new one, and he set out for another voyage in the blue with that childlike innocence

which in him was combined with the profoundest sagacity and the shrewdest intellect.

So many bizarre projects he has described to me, so many strange paradoxes he has defended to me, always with the same good faith! Sometimes he would maintain that one should live on nine sous a day, sometimes he would require one hundred thousand francs in order to be most comfortable. Once, when I asked him to reconcile the accounting, he responded to the objection that thirty thousand francs still remained unallocated. "Ah well! That is for the butter and the radishes. In what even slightly proper house does one not eat thirty thousand francs of radishes and butter?" I wish I could portray the look of sovereign disdain he cast on me as he gave that triumphal reason; that look said: "Decidedly Theo is nothing but a contemptible person, a skinned rat, a pitiful spirit; he understands nothing of a grand existence and he has all his life eaten only the salted butter of Brittany."

Les Jardies attracted a great deal of attention from the public when Balzac bought it with the honorable intention of making an investment for his mother. While riding on the railway that passes Ville-d'Avray, every passenger would look with curiosity at that little house, half cottage, half chalet, which rose in the middle of a clay slope.

This plot of land, in Balzac's opinion, was the best in the world; formerly, he asserted, a certain celebrated wine was grown there, and the grapes, thanks to an unparalleled exposure, baked like the grapes of Tokaj on the Bohemian hills. The sun, it is true, had the freedom to ripen the crop in this place, where there existed only a single tree. Balzac tried to enclose this property with walls, which became famous for obstinately collapsing or sliding all in one piece down the steep escarpment, and he dreamed of the most fabulous and the most exotic crops for this heavenly place. Here comes naturally the anecdote of the pineapples, which has been so often repeated that I would not tell it again except to add one truly characteristic trait. Here is the project: one hundred thousand feet of pineapples were planted within the boundaries of Les Jardies, transformed into greenhouses that required only limited heat due to the sunniness of the site. The pineapples were going to be sold for five francs instead of the one louis that they ordinarily cost, for a total of five hundred thousand francs; from this sum it was necessary to deduct one hundred thousand francs for the costs of cultivation, equipment, and coal; there remained therefore a net profit of four hundred thousand francs which would constitute a splendid profit for the happy proprietor, "without the least bit of writing," he added. That was nothing, Balzac had a thousand projects like this; but the beauty of this was

that we sought together, on the Boulevard Montmartre, a shop for the sale of the pineapples that were still in the form of seeds. The shop was to be painted black with thin gold stripes, and carry on its sign, in enormous letters: "PINEAPPLES FROM LES JARDIES."

For Balzac, the one hundred thousand pineapples were already raising their plumes of serrated leaves above their great lozenged cones under immense glass roofs: he saw them; he swelled in the high temperature of the greenhouse, he breathed in the tropical scent through his passionately open nostrils; and when, having returned to his home, he watched, while leaning on the window, the snow descend silently onto the bare slopes, he still only gave up his illusion with difficulty.

Yet he followed my advice to hold off on renting the shop until the following year in order to avoid an unnecessary expense.

I write my reminiscences as they return to me, without trying to place in order things which are better left apart. Besides, as Boileau said, transitions are the great difficulty of poetry, and of newspaper articles too, I will add; but modern journalists have neither as much conscience nor even more importantly as much leisure as the legislator of Parnasse.

Madame de Girardin professed for Balzac a lively admiration that he appreciated and that he acknowledged with his frequent visits, he who was so justifiably stingy with his time and his working hours. Never did a woman possess to such a high degree as Delphine, as I permitted myself to call her familiarly when we were together, the ability to stir the minds of her guests. With her, we always found ourselves to be particularly eloquent and each left her salon enthralled with himself. There was no stone so hard that she could not make a spark fly from it, and with Balzac, as you would expect, it was not necessary to strike the stone for very long: he sparkled and then lit up right away. Balzac was not precisely what one would call a talker, but he was quick with a reply, throwing a fine and decisive word into a discussion, changing the thread of the discourse, touching everything with lightness, and never going past a half smile: he had a verve, an eloquence, and an irresistible brio; and, as each person became silent to listen to him, with him, to the general satisfaction, the conversation would quickly descend into a soliloquy. The starting point was soon forgotten and he passed from an anecdote into a philosophical reflection, from an observation on manners to a local description; as he spoke his complexion would redden, his eyes would develop a distinctive luminosity, his voice would take on different inflections, and sometimes he would roar with laughter, amused by comic images that he saw before he described them. He announced in this way, like a sort of fanfare, the entry of his characters

and his humorous comments, and his hilarity was soon shared by his assistants. Although this was the age of dreamers with hair hanging loosely like a willow, of weepers in their garrets and of disillusioned Byronians, Balzac had that robust joy and power that one would attribute to Rabelais, and that Molière did not show except in his plays. His loud laugh coming from his sensual lips was that of a kindly god amused by the spectacle of the human marionettes, and who is distressed by nothing because he understands everything and grasps at once both sides of things. Neither the worries of an often precarious situation, nor the tedium of money, nor the fatigue of excessive work, nor the confinement of the study, nor the renunciation of all of the pleasures of life, nor even sickness could strike down this Herculean joviality, in my opinion one of the most striking characteristics of Balzac. He knocked out the hydras while laughing, happily tore the lions in two, and carried as if it were a hare the boar of Erymanthe on the mountainous muscles of his shoulders. At the least provocation this gaiety would burst forth and cause his strong chest to heave, which might surprise a person with a delicate constitution, but it had to be shared, no matter how much effort one made to remain serious. Do not believe however that Balzac was seeking to entertain his audience: he obeyed, affected by a kind of internal euphoria and painting with rapid strokes, with a comic intensity and an incomparable talent for satire, the bizarre phantasmagoria that danced in the dark chamber of his brain. I do not know how to better compare the impression produced by certain of his conversations than with that which one experiences while leafing through the strange drawings of *Songes Drolatiques*, by the master Alcofribas Nasier. These are of monstrous personages, composed of the most hybrid elements. Some have for a head a bellows in which the hole represents the eye, while others have an alembic flute for a nose; these ones walk with wheels in place of feet; those ones have the rounded belly of a cooking pot and wear a lid in place of a hat, but an intense life animates these fanciful beings, and one recognizes in their grimacing faces the vices, the follies and the passions of man. Some, although absurdly outside the realm of possibility, stop you like a portrait. One could give them a name.

When one listened to Balzac, a whole carnival of extravagant and real puppets frolicked before your eyes, wearing on their shoulders a colorful phrase, waving long sleeves of epithets, blowing their noses noisily with an adverb, smacking themselves with a bat of antitheses, pulling you by the tail of your coat, and whispering into your ear your secrets in a disguised and nasal voice, pirouetting, whirling in the midst of a sparkle of lights and of glitter. Nothing was more vertiginous, and at the end of one half hour, one

felt, like the student after the speech of Méphistophélès, a millstone turning in the brain.

He was not always so spirited, and on those occasions one of his favorite jokes was to imitate the German jargon of Nucingen or Schmucke, or otherwise to speak in rama, like the clients of the middle class boarding house of Madame Vauquer (née de Conflans). At the time that he wrote *Un Début dans la Vie* based on an outline of Madame de Surville, he was seeking proverbs that were slightly off for the art student Mistigris, to whom later, having found him to be full of spirit, he gave a fine place in *La Comédie Humaine*, under the name of the great landscape painter Léon de Lora. Here are some of his nonsensical proverbs: "He is like an ass on a plain." "I am like the hare, I die or I flee." "Good Counts make good sieves." "Extremes become blocked." "The slap always smells the herring"; and so on like this. A discovery of this type put him in a good humor, and he would pleasantly frolic like an elephant through the furniture and around the salon. For her part, Madame de Girardin was in quest of sayings for the famous lady of the seven little chairs of *Le Courrier de Paris*. She sometimes required my assistance, and if a stranger had entered, seeing this beautiful Delphine painting spirals through her golden hair with her white fingers, with a profoundly dreamlike air; Balzac, seated on one of the arms of the great upholstered chair on which Monsieur Girardin usually slept, his hands clenched in the bottoms of his pockets, his waistcoat turned back from his stomach, swinging his leg with a uniform rhythm, expressing with the tense muscles of his face an extraordinary mental focus; me planted between two cushions of the divan, like an opium eater seen in a hallucination; that stranger, certainly, could never have suspected what we were doing there, in so great a meditation; he would have supposed that Balzac was thinking of a new Madame Firmiani, Madame de Girardin of a role for Mademoiselle Rachel, and me of some sonnet. But it was nothing of the kind. As for the puns, Balzac, although his secret ambition was to create them, had, after painstaking efforts, recognized his notorious incapacity in this area, and kept to the slightly off proverbs, which preceded the rough puns brought into fashion by the school of good sense. What beautiful evenings that will never return! We were then far from foreseeing that this great and superb woman, carved fully out of marble from antiquity, that this stocky, robust, lively man, who combined in himself the vigor of the boar and the bull, half Hercules, half satyr, built to last longer than one hundred years, would soon sleep, one at Montmartre, the other at Père-Lachaise, and that, of the three, I alone would remain to preserve those memories that were already so distant and close to being lost.

Like his father, who died accidentally at more than eighty years of age, and who had flattered himself that he would become wealthy from the annuity scheme of Lafarge, Balzac believed in his longevity. Often he planned with me projects for the future. He was going to finish *La Comédie Humaine*, write the *Théorie de la Démarche*, compose the *Monographie de la Vertu*, fifty dramas, attain a great fortune, marry and have two children, "but not more; two children look good," he said, "on the front of a carriage." All of this could not fail to take a long time, and I pointed out that, once these tasks were accomplished, he would be around eighty years of age. "Eighty years!" he cried, "Bah! It's the flower of age." Monsieur Flourens, with his comforting theories, did not say it better.

One day that we dined together at the home of M. E. de Girardin, he told us a story about his father to show us the strength of the stock to which he belonged. Balzac's father, who had been hired to work in a prosecutor's office, ate following the custom of the time at the table of the master with the other clerks. Partridges were served. The prosecutor's wife, who had her eye on the new arrival, said to him: "Monsieur Balzac, do you know how to carve?" "Yes, Madame," responded the young man, blushing up to his ears; and he bravely took hold of the knife and fork. Entirely ignorant of culinary anatomy, he divided the partridge into four pieces, but with so much strength that he split the plate, sliced the tablecloth, and cut into the wood of the table. He was not nimble, but he was strong: the prosecutor's wife smiled, and from that day, Balzac, the young clerk, was treated with great kindness in that house.

This story that I have told seems lukewarm, but it is necessary to see the pantomime of Balzac as he imitated on his own plate his father's actions, with an air that was both frightened and resolute, mimicking the manner in which he seized his knife after having rolled up his sleeves and in which he sunk his fork into an imaginary partridge; Neptune hunting the monsters of the sea did not wield his trident with a more vigorous fist, and with what an immense weight he bore down with it! His cheeks became purple, his eyes left his head, but the operation ended with him casting upon the guests a look of innocent satisfaction trying to conceal itself in the guise of modesty.

Moreover, Balzac had in him the makings of a great actor: he possessed a full, sonorous, resonant voice, with a rich and powerful timbre, that he knew how to moderate and soften as needed, and he read in an admirable manner, a talent that most actors lack. Whatever he related, he performed it with intonations, grimaces and gestures that no comedian has surpassed in my opinion.

I find in *Marguerite*, by Madame de Girardin, this remembrance of Balzac. It is a character from the book who speaks.

"He related that Balzac had dined at his house on the preceding day, and that he had been more brilliant, more scintillating than ever. He very much amused us with the story of his trip to Austria. What fire! What verve! What power of imitation! It was marvelous. His manner of paying the postilions is an invention that only a novelist of genius could have discovered. 'I was very embarrassed at each stopping point,' he said, 'how was I going to pay? I did not know a word of German, I did not know the currency of the country. It was very difficult. Here is what I invented. I had a bag full of small silver coins, some kreuzers ... When I arrived at the stopping point, I would take up my bag; the postilion would come to the window of the carriage; I would watch his eyes attentively, and I would put in his hand one kreuzer, ... two kreuzer, ... then three, then four, etc., until I saw him smile ... when he smiled, I understood that I had given him one kreuzer too much ... quickly I would take back my coin and my man was paid.'"

At Les Jardies, he read *Mercadet* to me, the original *Mercadet*, by far more sweeping, complicated and dense than the piece arranged for the Gymnase by d'Ennery, with so much delicacy and skill. Balzac, who read like Tieck, without indicating acts, scenes, or names, utilized a voice that was particular to and perfectly recognizable for each character; the voices that he gave to the different kinds of creditors were hilariously funny: there were the hoarse, the honeyed, the hasty, the slow, the menacing, the pleading. They shrieked, wailed, scolded, muttered, screamed in every possible and impossible tone. Debt first sang a solo that soon an immense choir took up. He brought out creditors from everywhere, from behind the stove, from below the bed, from the drawers of the commode; they came from the chimney; they passed through the keyhole; others entered through the window like lovers; these sprung from the bottom of a trunk like those devilish toys that take you by surprise, those moved across the walls as if they were passing by an English ambush, it was a mob, an uproar, an invasion, truly a rising tide. Mercadet might well have shaken them off, when others always returned to start an assault, and as far as the horizon one could make out a somber swarm of creditors on the march, arriving like legions of termites to devour their prey. I do not know if this piece was better when performed this way, but no other performance produced such an effect.

Balzac, during this reading of *Mercadet*, occupied, partially reclining, a long divan in the salon of Les Jardies because he had sprained his ankle

when he slipped, like his walls, on the clay of his property. A stray hair, sticking through the fabric, poked the skin of his leg and bothered him. "The fabric is too thin, the hay passes through it; you will need to put a thick canvas beneath it," he said while pulling at the hair that annoyed him.

François, the Caleb of this Ravenswood, would not listen to this mocking of the splendors of the manor. He corrected his master and said: *horsehair*. "The upholsterer has cheated me?" responded Balzac. "They are all the same. I had insisted that he use hay! Cursed thief!"

The splendors of Les Jardies were mostly imaginary. All of the friends of Balzac remember having seen written in charcoal upon the bare walls or veneer of gray paper: "Rosewood paneling, tapestry of the Gobelins, Venetian mirrors, paintings by Raphaël." Gerard de Nerval had already decorated an apartment in this manner, so this did not shock me. As for Balzac, he believed literally in the gold, the marble and the silk; but, he did not complete Les Jardies and if he led others to laugh at his pipe dreams, he knew at least that he had built himself an eternal home, a monument "more durable than iron," an immense city, populated with his creations and gilded by the rays of his glory.

V

Due to an oddity of nature that he shared with several of the most poetic writers of this age, such as Chateaubriand, Madame de Staël, George Sand, Mérimée, Janin, Balzac possessed neither the gift nor the love of verse, despite the effort that he otherwise made to attain them. On this point, his judgment that was so fine, so profound, so sagacious was at fault; he admired work somewhat aimlessly and in a way in line with public notoriety. I did not believe, even though he professed a great respect for Victor Hugo, that he had ever truly appreciated the lyrical qualities of the poet, while at the same time the sculpted and colored prose amazed him. He, who was so laborious and who rewrote a sentence as many times as a versifier could rework an Alexandrine on an anvil, found working on meter to be puerile, tedious, and without utility. He would have voluntarily awarded a bushel of peas to those who could manage to pass an idea through the narrow ring of rhythm, as Alexander did for the Greek who was trained to throw a ball through a ring from a long distance; verse, with its fixed and pure form, its elliptical speech little suited to a multiplicity of details, seemed to him to be an obstacle invented on a whim, an unnecessary difficulty or a mnemonic device taken from primitive times. His doctrine was in that way nearly the same as that of Stendhal: "Does the

idea that a work has been made while hopping on one leg add to the pleasure that it produces?" The Romantic school holds in its heart some followers, partisans of the absolute truth, who rejected verse as trivial or unnatural. If Talma said: "I do not want fine verses!" Beyle said: "I do not want verses at all." This was the basis of the sentiments of Balzac, however in order to appear open-minded, comprehensive, universal, he sometimes in society pretended to admire poetry, just as the middle class simulate great enthusiasm for music that bores them profoundly. He was always shocked to see me write verse and take pleasure from it. "That is not copy," he would say, and if he held me in any esteem, I owed it to my prose. All of the writers, young then, who associated themselves with the literary movement represented by Hugo, used, like the master, the lyre or the pen: Alfred de Vigny, Sainte-Beuve, Alfred de Musset, spoke interchangeably the language of the gods and the language of men. I too, if I am permitted to mention myself after such glorious names, have had since the beginning this double aptitude. It is always easy for poets to descend to prose. The bird may walk as needed, but the lion cannot fly. Those who are born to write prose never rise to poetry however poetic they may be elsewhere. Rhythmic speech is a particular gift, and one can possess it without being a great genius, while it is often refused to superior minds. Among the proudest who appear to disdain it, more than one keeps to himself a secret resentment to not possess it.

Among the two thousand characters in *La Comédie Humaine*, one finds two poets: Canalis, of *Modeste Mignon*, and Lucien de Rubempré, of *Splendeurs et Misères des Courtisanes*. Balzac portrayed both of them as having traits that were not particularly favorable. Canalis is dry, cold, sterile, petty, an adroit arranger of words, a maker of imitation jewelry, who sets rhinestones in gilded silver, and makes necklaces of artificial pearls. His volumes, with many blank spaces, wide margins, and large gaps, contain only a melodious nothingness, monotonous music, suitable only to cause young boarders to fall asleep or dream. Balzac, who ordinarily shapes with warmth the interests of his characters, seems to take a secret pleasure in ridiculing this one and putting him in embarrassing positions: he challenges his vanity with a thousand ironies and a thousand sarcasms, and finishes by taking from him Modeste Mignon with her great fortune, to give her to Ernest de la Brière. This conclusion, in contrast to the beginning of the story, sparkles with concealed malice and fine mockery. One would say that Balzac is personally happy at the good trick that he has played on Canalis. He avenges, in his own way, the angels, the sylphs, the lakes, the

swans, the willows, the skiffs, the stars and the lyres that had been used so abundantly by the poet.

If in *Canalis* we have the false poet, reserving his meager inspiration and putting it behind a dam so that it can flow, foam and sound for a few minutes in order to seem like a cascade, the man used to taking advantage of his laboriously wrought literary successes to serve his political ambitions, the man with material interests who is in love with money, medals, pensions and honors, despite his elegiac attitudes and pose as an angel who misses being in heaven, Lucien de Rubempré shows us the poet who is lazy, frivolous, oblivious, capricious, and as nervous as a woman, incapable of prolonged effort, without moral force, living in the hooks of actresses and courtesans, a puppet whose strings the terrible Vautrin, under the pseudonym Carlos Herrera, pulls as he pleases. Despite all of his vices, Lucien is seductive; Balzac has equipped him with spirit, beauty, youth, and elegance; women adore him; but he ends by hanging himself at the Conciergerie. Balzac did everything he could to successfully complete the marriage of Clotilde de Grandlieu with the author of *Marguerite*; unfortunately the demands of morality intervened, and what would the Faubourg Saint-Germain have said of *La Comédie Humaine* if the student of Jacques Collin the convict had married the daughter of a duke?

Regarding the author of *Marguerite*, I will note here a bit of information that could amuse those who are interested in literature. The few sonnets that Lucien de Rubempré shows as a sample of his volume of verse to the bookseller Dauriat are not the work of Balzac, who did not write verse, and asked his friends for those that he happened to need. The sonnet on the daisy is by Madame de Girardin, the sonnet on the camellia is by de Lassailly, and the one on the tulip is by myself.

Modeste Mignon also contained a piece of verse, but I do not know the author.

As I have said regarding *Mercadet*, Balzac was an admirable reader, and he very much wanted, one day, to read some of my own verses. He read to me, among others, *La Fontaine du Cimetière*. Like all prose writers, he read only for the meaning, and tried to conceal the rhythm that poets, when they deliver their verses out loud, in contrast accentuate in a manner intolerable to everyone, but which delights them alone, and we had together, on this point, a long discussion, which, like always, served only to cause each of us to persist in our particular opinion.

The great literary man of *La Comédie Humaine* is Daniel d'Arthez, a writer who was serious, a hard worker, and for a long time buried, before achieving his success, in immense studies of philosophy, history and

linguistics. Balzac feared facility, and he did not believe that a rapidly produced work could be good. In this context, journalism held a singular repugnance for him, and he regarded the time and talent consecrated to it to be wasted; he didn't hold journalists in any higher regard, and he, who was however such a great critic, despised criticism. The unflattering portraits that he has drawn of Etienne Loustau, of Nathan, of Vernisset, of Andoche Finot, represent fairly well his true opinion of the place of the press. Emile Blondet, introduced into that bad company to represent the good writer, is compensated for his articles in the imaginary *Débats* of *La Comédie Humaine* with a rich marriage to the widow of a general, which permits him to leave journalism.

Moreover, Balzac never worked toward the point of view of a newspaper. He brought his novels to the magazines and daily newspapers as they had come to him, without preparing any breaks or interesting twists at the end of each installment, to increase the desire for the continuation. His work was broken up into sections that were roughly the same length, and sometimes the description of an armchair would start on one day and finish the next. With justification, he did not want to divide his work into little dramatic or vaudevillian tableaux; he thought of nothing but the book. This working method was often to the detriment of the immediate success that journalism requires of the authors it employs. Eugène Sue, Alexandre Dumas were more frequently victorious in the battles each morning than then captivated the public. He did not obtain immense popularity, like that of *Les Mystères de Paris* and *Le Juif-Errant*, of *Les Mousquetaires* and of *Monte-Cristo*. *Les Paysans*, a masterpiece, even caused a great number of readers to cancel their subscriptions to the *Presse*, where the first installment appeared. Its publication had to be suspended. Every day letters arrived that demanded that it be ended. Balzac was found to be boring!

There was still not a good understanding of the great idea of *La Comédie Humaine*, to take on modern society and write about Paris and our times the book that sadly no ancient civilization has left for us. The collected edition of *La Comédie Humaine*, by assembling all of the scattered works, put into relief the philosophical intention of the writer. From that date forward, Balzac grew considerably in public opinion, he finally ceased being considered "the most productive of our novelists," a stereotyped phrase that irritated him as much as "the author of *Eugénie Grandet*."

There have been a number of critiques on Balzac and he has been discussed in many ways, but in my opinion one very characteristic feature has not been emphasized: this point is the absolute modernity of his genius.

Balzac owes nothing to antiquity; for him there are neither Greeks nor Romans, and he has no need to cry for deliverance from them. One does not find in the composition of his talent any trace of Homer, of Virgil, of Horace, not even of *De Viris Illustribus*; nobody was ever less classical.

Balzac, like Gavarni, observed his contemporaries; and, in art, the supreme difficulty is to portray that which one sees before one's eyes; one can pass through one's time without appreciating it, and that is what many eminent minds have done.

To be of his time, nothing would appear to be simpler but nothing is more difficult! To wear no glasses, neither blue nor green, to think with his own brain, to use the speech of the present day, not stitch together a colorful fabric from the phrases of his predecessors! Balzac possessed this rare merit. The ages have their perspective and their distance; at that distance the great masses move away, the lines end, the flickering details disappear; with the help of classical memories, of melodious names from antiquity, the least rhetorician could create a tragedy, a poem, an historical study. But, to find yourself in the crowd, to be elbowed by it, and to appreciate its features, understand its flow, sort out its personalities, outline the features of so many diverse beings, to show the motives for their actions, that demands an entirely special genius, and this genius, the author of *La Comédie Humaine* had to a degree that no one has equaled and probably no one will equal.

This profound understanding of modern things rendered Balzac, it must be said, insensitive to sculptural beauty. He read with a careless eye the stanzas of white marble with which Greek art sung the perfection of the human form. In the museum of antiquities, he looked at the Venus de Milo without great ecstasy, but the Parisian woman who has stopped in front of the immortal statue, draped in her long cashmere shawl running without a crease from the neck to the heel, wearing her hat with a veil from Chantilly, gloved with her tight Jouvin gloves, showing from under the hem of her flounced dress the polished tip of her worn boots, made his eyes sparkle with pleasure. He analyzed her coquettish allure, he savored at length her skillful graces, only to find as she did that the goddess was too heavysset and would not be an attractive addition to the homes of Mesdames de Beauséant, de Listomère, or d'Espard. Ideal beauty, with its serene and pure lines, was too simple, too cold, too harmonious for this complicated, exuberant and diverse genius. He also says somewhere: "It is necessary to be Raphaël to portray many virgins." *Character* pleased him more than *style*, and he preferred looks to beauty. In his portraits of women, he never fails to put a mark, a crease, a wrinkle, a red blemish, a softened and tired corner, a vein that is too apparent, some detail indicating the bruises of life

that a poet, in tracing the same image, would surely have suppressed, mistakenly without a doubt.

I do not intend to criticize Balzac in this. This *fault* is his principal *strength*. He accepted nothing of the mythologies and traditions of the past, and he did not know, happily for us, that ideal that was achieved with the verses of the poets, the marbles of Greece and Rome, the paintings of the Renaissance, which stands between the eyes of artists and reality. He loved the woman of our day just as she is, and not as a pale statue; he loved her for her virtues, for her vices, for her fantasies, for her shawls, for her dresses, for her hats, and followed her across her life, far beyond the point in the journey where love abandons her. He prolonged her youth by many seasons, gave her springs with the summers of Saint-Martin, and gilded her twilight years with the most splendid rays. We are so classical, in France, that we have not perceived, after two thousand years, that roses, in our climate, do not bloom in April as in the descriptions of poets of antiquity, but in June, and that our women begin to be beautiful at the age at which those of Greece, who are more precocious, cease to be. How many charming types he has imagined or reproduced! Madame Firmiani, the Duchesse de Maufrigneuse, the Princess de Cadignan, Madame de Morsauf, Lady Dudley, the Duchess de Langeais, Madame Jules, Modeste Mignon, Diane de Chaulieu, without counting the middle class women, the seamstresses and the ladies of ill repute.

And how he loved and knew that modern Paris, whose beauty the amateurs of local color and the picturesque of that time appreciated so little! He roamed across it in every direction night and day; there is not a forgotten alley, a foul passage, a narrow, muddy and black street which did not become under his pen an etching of Rembrandt, full of teeming and mysterious darkness or sparkling with a trembling star of light. Wealth and poverty, pleasure and suffering, shame and glory, grace and ugliness, he knew all of his beloved town; it was for him an enormous, hybrid, formidable monster, an octopus with one hundred thousand arms that he heard and saw as a living thing, and which constituted in his eyes an immense individual. See with regard to this the marvelous pages placed at the beginning of *La Fille aux Yeux d'Or*, in which Balzac, impinging on the art of the musician, had wanted, as in a grand orchestral symphony, to make all of the voices sing together, all of the sobbing, all of the cries, all of the rumors, all of the grinding of Paris at work!

From this *modernity* on which I purposefully dwell arose, without his suspecting it, a difficulty in labor that Balzac experienced in his efforts to complete his work: the French language as refined by the classics of the

seventeenth century is not suitable, when one conforms to it, other than to express general ideas, and to portray conventional figures in a vague setting. To describe this multiplicity of details, of characters, of types, of architectures, of furnishings, Balzac was obliged to create for himself a special language, composed of all of the technical terms, all of the argots of science, of the workshop, of the theater, even of the lecture hall. Every word that said something was welcomed, and the sentence, in order to receive it, opened a space, a parenthetical expression, and lengthened itself obligingly. It is this that made superficial critics say that Balzac did not know how to write. He possessed, even though he did not know it, a style and a very beautiful style, the necessary, inevitable, and mathematical style of his ideas!

VI

No one could have the ambition to write a complete biography of Balzac; any relationship with him was necessarily limited by gaps, absences, disappearances. Work absolutely ruled the life of Balzac, and if, as he himself says with touching sensitivity in a letter to his sister, he has painlessly sacrificed the joys and distractions of existence to this jealous god, it cost him to renounce all company that might have led to friendship. To reply with a few words to a long letter became for him who was overburdened with labor a prodigality that he could rarely permit himself; he was the slave of his work and a voluntary slave. He had, with a very good and very tender heart, the selfishness of the great worker. And who could have dreamed of being mad at his pressured negligences and his apparent forgetfulness, when one saw the results of his escapes or his seclusions? When, the work completed, he would reappear, one would have said that he had left you the day before, and he would take up the interrupted conversation once again, as if sometimes six months and more had not passed. He made trips within France to study localities that he included in *Scènes de Province*, and he withdrew to the houses of friends, in Touraine, or in the Charente, finding there a calm that the creditors did not always allow him in Paris. After some great work, he permitted himself, occasionally, a longer excursion to Germany, northern Italy, or Switzerland; but these rapid excursions, made with the preoccupations of bills that were due to be paid, contracts to fulfill, and limited funds for travel, may have fatigued him more than they gave him rest. His vast gaze took in the skies, the horizons, the mountains, the countryside, the monuments, the houses, the interiors to commit them to that universal and meticulous memory that

never failed him. Superior in this to descriptive poets, Balzac saw man at the same time as nature; he studied the physiognomies, the manners, the passions, the characters in the same glance as locations, clothing and furnishings. One detail sufficed for him, as the least fragment of bone did for Cuvier, to accurately imagine and reconstitute a personality glimpsed while passing. Balzac has often been praised, and rightly so, for his power of observation; but, however great he was, it is not necessary to imagine that the author of *La Comédie Humaine* always drew from nature his portraits whose truth was so clearly from elsewhere. His process did not resemble in any way that of Henri Monnier, who followed in real life an individual in order to make a sketch with a pencil and a pen, drawing his least gestures, writing down his most insignificant phrases in order to obtain at the same time a photographic plate and a page of shorthand notes. Buried most of the time in the excavations of his work, Balzac could not materially observe the two thousand characters who play their role in his comedy of one hundred acts; but every man, when he looks inward, contains humanity: it is a microcosm in which nothing is missing.

He has, not always, but often observed within himself the numerous types that live in his work. That is why they are so complete. No one could absolutely comprehend the life of another; in such a case, there are motives that remain obscure, unknown details, actions of which one loses track. In even the most faithful portrait, some creativity is necessary. Balzac has thus created much more than he saw. His rare faculties of the analyst, of the physiologist, of the anatomist, have merely served the poet in him, just as the assistant serves the professor at his lectern when he passes him the substances that he needs for his demonstrations.

Perhaps this could be the place to define the *truth* as understood by Balzac; in this time of realism, it is good to be understood on this point. The truth of art is not that of nature; everything that is represented through the means of art necessarily contains some element of the conventional; make it as small as possible, it still exists, be it perspective in painting, language in literature. Balzac accentuates, magnifies, enlarges, prunes, adds, shadows, illuminates, avoids or approaches men or things according to the effect that he wants to produce. He is *truthful*, without doubt, but with augmentations and sacrifices for *art*. He prepares backgrounds that are somber and darkened with charcoal for his luminous figures, he puts white backgrounds behind his dark figures. Like Rembrandt, he sets the light of day on the brow or nose of the character; sometimes, in his description, he obtains fantastic and bizarre results, by placing, without saying anything, a microscope under the eye of the reader; the details then appear with a

supernatural clarity, an amplified minutia, some unbelievable and formidable magnifications; the tissues, the scaliness, the pores, the veins, the blemishes, the fibers, the capillaries take on an enormous importance, and turn a visage that is insignificant to the naked eye into a sort of fanciful mask as amusing as those that were sculpted under the cornice of the Pont-Neuf and vermiculated by time. The characters are also pushed to excess, as it is suited to each type: if Baron Hulot is a libertine, he additionally personifies lust: he is a man and a vice, an individual and an abstraction; he unites in himself all of the scattered traits of the character. Where a writer of lesser genius would have drawn a portrait, Balzac has created a figure. Men do not have as many muscles as Michelangelo gives them to suggest the idea of strength. Balzac is full of such useful exaggerations, of those dark strokes that enhance and support the outline; he dreams while writing, like the masters, and leaves his mark on everything. As this is not a literary critique, but a biographical study that I am writing, I will not take these remarks farther than necessary. Balzac, whom the Realist school seems to wish to claim as its leader, has no connection to its features.

Unlike certain literary persons who feed on nothing but their own genius, Balzac read a great deal and with a prodigious rapidity. He loved books, and he created a beautiful library that he intended to leave to the town of his birth, an idea that the indifference of the townspeople made him later abandon. He absorbed in a few days the voluminous works of Swedenborg, which were owned by his mother, who was rather preoccupied with mysticism at that time, and that reading was responsible for *Séraphita-Séraphitus*, one of the most astonishing products of modern literature. Never did Balzac approach, or move closer to ideal beauty than in that book: the ascension of the mountain has a quality that is ethereal, supernatural, and luminous that lifts you from the earth. The only two colors that are employed are celestial blue and snow white with a few pearlescent tones for shadow. I know nothing more intoxicating than this beginning. The panorama of Norway, with its sharply cut coastline seen from this height, dazzles and gives one vertigo.

Louis Lambert was also influenced by the reading of Swedenborg; but soon Balzac, who had taken on the eagle wings of the mystics to soar into the infinite, descended to the earth that we inhabit, even though his robust lungs could have breathed indefinitely the thin air that is deadly for the weak: he abandoned the world beyond after that flight and returned to real life. Perhaps his remarkable genius would have gone out of view too quickly if he had continued to soar toward the unfathomable immensities of metaphysics, and we should be happy that he limited himself to *Louis*

Lambert and *Séraphita-Séraphitus*, which represent sufficiently, in *La Comédie Humaine*, the supernatural side, and open a door that is sufficiently large into the invisible world.

I now move on to a few more intimate details. The great Goethe had a horror of three things: one of the things was tobacco smoke, I am not permitted to say the two others. Balzac, like the Jupiter of the German poetic Olympus, could not stand tobacco in any form at all; he denounced the pipe and forbid the cigar. He did not tolerate even a light Spanish cigarette; the Asian hookah alone found favor with him, and yet he only tolerated that as a curiosity and because of its local color. In his diatribes against the herb of Nicot, he did not imitate the doctor who, during a dissertation on the dangers of tobacco, does not hesitate to take ample doses from a large box of tobacco near him: he never smoked. His *Théorie des Excitants* contains an indictment against tobacco, and there is no doubt that if he had been Sultan, like Amurath, he would have beheaded relapsed and obstinate smokers. He reserved all of his predilections for coffee, which did him so much harm and might have killed him, although he was built to become a centenarian.

Was Balzac wrong or right? Is tobacco, as he maintained, a deadly poison and does it intoxicate those that it does not turn stupid? Is it the opium of the Occident that dulls the will and the intelligence? These are questions that I cannot answer; but I am going to list here the names of some celebrated personages of our age, some of whom smoked while the others did not smoke: Goethe, Heinrich Heine, uniquely for Germans, did not smoke; Byron smoked; Victor Hugo does not smoke, neither does Alexandre Dumas père; on the other hand Alfred de Musset, Eugène Sue, Georges Sand, Mérimée, Paul de Saint-Victor, Emile Augier, Ponsard, smoked and still smoke; however they are not exactly imbeciles.

This aversion, moreover, was shared by nearly all men who were born in our century or a little before. Only sailors and soldiers smoked then; at the odor of the pipe or the cigar, women fainted: they have become much tougher since then, and more than one pair of rosy lips has pressed with love the golden tip of a cigar, in a sitting room turned into a smoking room. Dowagers and turbaned mothers alone have preserved their old antipathy, and stoically watch their unfashionable salons be deserted by the youth.

Every time that Balzac is obliged, for the credibility of the story, to allow one of his characters to indulge in this horrible habit, his brief and disdainful sentence betrays a secret disapproval: "As for de Marsay," he said, "he was busy smoking cigars." And he must have really loved this captain of dandyism to permit him to smoke in his work.

A fragile and elegant young woman had without doubt inspired this aversion in Balzac, although that is a question that I cannot answer definitively. Still it's true that the tax collector never earned a sou from him. Regarding women, Balzac, who described them so well, must have known them, and one understands the sense that the Bible attaches to this word. In one of the letters that he writes to Madame de Surville, his sister, Balzac, quite young and completely unknown, sets down an ideal for his life in two words: "To be celebrated and to be loved." The first part of this program, which all artists map out for themselves, had been realized in every way. Was the second also accomplished? The opinion of the most intimate friends of Balzac is that he practiced the chastity that he recommended to others, and shared at most platonic love; but Madame de Surville laughs at this idea, with a smile of feminine delicacy and full of discreet reserve. She maintains that her brother was unfailingly discreet, and that if he had wanted to speak, he would have had many things to say. This must be true, and without doubt the safe of Balzac contained more of the notes with delicate, sloping handwriting than the lacquered box of Canalis. There is, in his work, the scent of a woman: odor di femina; when one enters there, one hears behind the doors that close on the hidden staircase the rustling of silk and the creaking of shoes. The semicircular and padded salon on the Rue de Batailles, of which I have quoted the description inserted by the author in *La Fille aux Yeux d'Or*, did not remain completely virginal, as many of us had assumed. In the course of our close friendship, which lasted from 1836 until his death, only once did Balzac make allusion, with the most respectful and the most tender terms, to an attachment of his early youth, and even then he gave me only the first name of the person whose memory, after so many years, still made his eyes moisten. Had he said any more to me, I certainly would not have abused his confidences; the genius of a great writer belongs to all of the world, but his heart is his own. I touch only briefly on this tender and delicate side of Balzac's life, because I have nothing to say that does not honor him. This reserve and this mystery are those of a gentleman. If he was loved as he wished in the dreams of his youth, the world knows nothing of it.

Do not imagine after these reflections that Balzac was austere and prudish in his speech: the author of *Les Contes Drolatiques* had been nourished with too much Rabelais and was too pantagruelistic to be unable to laugh; he knew good stories and invented them: his broad jokes interspersed with Gallic crudities would have made the sanctimonious and horrified members of society cry out *shocking*; but his laughing and talkative lips were sealed like a tomb when there was a question of a serious

sentiment. He scarcely allowed his closest friends to surmise his love for a foreign woman of distinction, a love of which one can speak, since it was crowned by marriage. It was that passion that had been felt for a long time that necessitated his distant excursions, although their object remained until the last day a mystery for his friends.

Absorbed by his work, Balzac did not think until rather late of the theater, for which the general opinion judged him, wrongly to my mind, after a few more or less risky efforts, to be hardly suited. He who created so many types, analyzed so many characters, gave life to so many people, should succeed on the stage; but, as I have said, Balzac was not spontaneous, and one cannot correct the proofs of a drama. If he had lived, after a dozen works, he would assuredly have found his form and attained success; *La Marâtre* that played at the Théâtre-Historique was close to a masterpiece. *Mercadet*, lightly edited by an intelligent arranger, enjoyed a long posthumous success at the Gymnase.

Nevertheless, the factor that motivated his efforts was mostly, I must say, the idea of a windfall that would liberate him all at once from his financial predicament rather than a real vocation. Theater, as we know, is much more profitable than books; the continuing nature of the performances, on which a rather large royalty is drawn, produces quickly by accumulation some considerable sums. If the strategic work is greater, the material labor is less. Several dramas are necessary to fill a volume, and while you promenade or rest idly with slippers on your feet, the footlights are illuminated, the scenery descends from the ceiling, the actors recite and gesticulate, and you find yourself having made more money than you would have by scribbling for an entire week bent painfully over your desk. Such melodrama has more value to its author than *Notre-Dame de Paris* to Victor Hugo and *Les Parents Pauvres* to Balzac.

It's curious that Balzac who contemplated, elaborated, and corrected his novels with such unrelenting meticulousness, seemed, when it concerned the theater, to become dizzy from the rapidity of his work. Not only did he not rewrite his theater pieces eight or ten times like his books, he really did not write them at all. Having just come upon his first idea, he chose a day for the reading and called his friends to request their assistance in the project; Ourliac, Lassailly, Laurent-Jan, myself and others, have often been summoned in the middle of the night or at fabulously early times of the morning. It was necessary to drop everything; every minute of delay caused the loss of millions.

A pressing note from Balzac summoned me one day to come right away to 104 Rue de Richelieu, where he had a lodging in the house of

Buisson the tailor. I found Balzac wrapped in his monastic frock, and hopping up and down with impatience on the blue and white rug of a tidy attic room that had walls upholstered in light brown percale embellished with blue, because, despite his apparent neglectfulness, he had an understanding of interior design, and always prepared a comfortable den for his laborious vigils; in none of his lodgings was there the picturesque disorder dear to artists.

"Finally, here is Theo!" he cried when he saw me. "You are lazy, slow, slothlike, an obstacle, hurry up then; you should have been here an hour ago. Tomorrow I am reading Harel a great drama in five acts."

"And you would like to have my advice," I responded while settling myself into an armchair like a man who is preparing himself to endure a long lecture.

From my attitude Balzac understood my thought, and he said to me in the most straightforward way, "The drama is not written."

"The devil," I said. "Oh well, you will need to delay the reading for six weeks."

"No. We are going to rush the dramorama to get paid. At this time I have a heavy debt that is due."

"From now until tomorrow, it's impossible; there would not be time to copy it."

"Here is how I have arranged things. You will do an act, Ourliac another, Laurent-Jan the third, de Belloy the fourth, me the fifth, and I will read at noon as agreed. One act of a drama has no more than four or five hundred lines; one can write five hundred lines of dialogue in a day and in a night."

"Tell me the subject, outline the plan, describe to me in a few words the characters, and I will get to work," I responded to him, somewhat alarmed.

"Ah!" he cried with an air of superb weariness and magnificent disdain, "if I need to tell you the subject, we will never be finished."

I did not think I was being inappropriate in posing that question, which seemed quite pointless to Balzac.

After a brief instruction that I obtained with difficulty, I set to work to put together a scene from which only a few words remained in the final work, which was not read the next day, as one might well believe. I do not know what the other collaborators did; but the only one who seriously joined in, this was Laurent-Jan, to whom the play is dedicated.

That play, it was *Vautrin*. Everyone knows that the dynastic and pyramidal tuft of hair that Frédéric Lemaître fantasized wearing in his

disguise as a Mexican general brought down on the work the criticism of the authorities; *Vautrin*, forbidden, had only a single performance, and poor Balzac remained like Perrette in front of his overturned milk jug. The prodigious proceeds that he had anticipated as the probable product of his drama vanished into ciphers, which did not stop him from refusing very nobly the compensation offered by the ministry.

At the beginning of this study, I told you about the tendencies toward dandyism that were demonstrated by Balzac, I spoke of his blue coat with solid gold buttons, his monstrous cane topped with a group of turquoise stones, his appearances in society and in the extravagant salon; this splendor lasted only for a period of time, and Balzac recognized that he was not suited to play the role of Alcibiades or Brummel. Everyone could encounter him, particularly in the morning, when he rushed to the printers carrying copy or seeking proofs, in an infinitely less splendid outfit. I recall the green hunting jacket, with brass buttons representing the head of a fox, the black and gray checked pants that extended to his feet, which were encased in large laced shoes, the red scarf wrapped around the neck like a rope, and the hat that was at the same time both bristly and smooth, its blue bleached by sweat, which covered rather than clothed "the most fertile of our novelists." Despite the disorder and poverty of his dress, nobody would have been tempted to take for an unknown commoner this large man with the blazing eyes, flaring nostrils, and cheeks struck with violent tones, all illuminated by genius, who passed while carried away by his dream like a whirlwind! At the sight of him, the mocking stopped on the urchin's lips, and the serious man did not begin to smile. Everyone recognized one of the kings of thought.

Sometimes, to the contrary, he would be seen walking with slow steps, his nose in the air, his eyes searching, following one side of the street then examining the other, not daydreaming, but looking at the signs. He was looking for names to christen his characters. He maintained with some justification that a name could not be invented any more than a word. According to him, names arose on their own like languages; besides real names possessed a life, a meaning, a destiny, a mystical significance, and it was impossible to place too much importance on their choice. Léon Gozlan has told in a charming way, in his *Balzac en Pantoufles*, how the famous Z. Marcas of the *Revue Parisienne* was found.

A sign of a chimney man provided the name of Gubetta that had long been sought by Victor Hugo, who was no less careful than Balzac in the names of his characters.

This demanding life of nocturnal work had, despite his strong constitution, left its traces on the features of Balzac, and we find in *Albert Savarus* a portrait of him, written by himself, that represents him such as he was at that time (1842), with some minor differences:

"... A superb head, black hair already streaked with some white, hair like that of Saint Peter and Saint Paul in our paintings, with thick shining curls, stiff like horsehair, a round white neck like that of a woman, a magnificent forehead, divided by the powerful furrows that great projects, great thoughts, strong reflections inscribe on the the foreheads of great men; an olive complexion marbled with red marks, a square nose, eyes of fire, then the hollow cheeks, with two long lines full of suffering, a mouth with a sardonic smile and a small chin that was narrow and too short; crow's feet at his temples, sunken eyes, rolling under the eyebrow arches like two burning globes; but despite all of these signs of violent passion, a calm manner, profoundly accepting, the voice of a penetrating sweetness which surprised me with its facility, the true voice of an orator, sometimes pure and astute, sometimes insinuating, and thunderous when necessary, then pliant with sarcasm, and then becoming incisive. Monsieur Albert Savaron is of middle height, neither fat nor thin; finally, he has the hands of a prelate."

In this portrait, which is incidentally very faithful, Balzac idealizes himself a little for the needs of the novel, and subtracts from himself a few kilograms of portliness, license which is certainly permitted to a beloved hero of the Duchess d'Argaiolo and Mademoiselle Philomène de Watteville. This novel of *Albert Savarus*, one of the least known and least quoted of Balzac, contains many transposed details on his habits of life and of work; one could even see there, if it was permissible to lift those veils, secrets of another kind.

Balzac had left the Rue des Batailles for Les Jardies; he then went to live at Passy. The house in which he lived, situated on a steep slope, offered a unique architectural layout. One entered there

A little like wine enters bottles

It was necessary to *descend* three floors to reach the first. The entry door, which was on the side of the house that faced the road, opened nearly into the roof, like a mansard. I dined there once with L. G. It was a strange dinner, with its dishes based on economical recipes invented by Balzac. At my express request, the famous onion purée, endowed with so many healthy and symbolic qualities and which almost killed Lassailly, did not appear. But the wines were marvelous! Each bottle had a story, and Balzac told it

with an eloquence, a verve, a conviction without equal. The wine of Bordeaux had gone around the world three times; the Châteauneuf-du-Pape traced back to legendary times; the rum came from a barrel rolled for more than a century by the sea, which had to be opened with blows from an axe, because the crust that had been formed around it by shellfish, coral and seaweed was thick. My palate, surprised, irritated by the acidic flavors, protested in vain against these illustrious origins. Balzac maintained the solemnity of a soothsayer, and despite the proverb, I kept my eyes fixed on him, but I did not make him laugh!

For dessert, we had pears of a ripeness, a size, a tenderness and a quality that would do honor to a royal table. Balzac devoured five or six of them with the juice running down his chin; he believed that this fruit was good for him, and he ate them in such a quantity as much for health as for sweetness. Already he felt the first effects of the illness that would take him. Death, with its skeletal fingers, was touching this robust body to know where to attack it, and finding no weakness there, killed it through excess and hypertrophy. The cheeks of Balzac were already lined and marked with those red spots that simulate health to inattentive eyes; but for the observer, the yellow tones of hepatitis surrounded the tired eyelids with their golden halo; the expression, brightened by this warm sepia hue, appeared even more vivacious and shining and lessened anxieties.

At that time, Balzac was very preoccupied with the occult sciences, palmistry, and card reading; he had been told of an oracle even more astonishing than Mademoiselle Lenormand, and he persuaded me, as well as Madame E. de Girardin and Méry, to go and consult her with him. The prophetess lived in Auteuil, I no longer know in which street; that matters little to my story, because the address that was given was false. We came upon an honorable middle class family on holiday: the husband, the wife, and an old mother in whom Balzac, sure of his facts, persisted in finding a mystical air. The good woman, not flattered to have been taken for a sorceress, became angry; the husband took us for tricksters or crooks; the young woman laughed loudly, and the servant hastened prudently to lock up the silver. We had no choice but to withdraw after our blunder; but Balzac maintained that we were in the right place, and having climbed back into the carriage, muttered insults at the old lady: "Demon, harpy, magician, vampire, worm, monster, lemur, ghoul, snake charmer, creature," and all of the bizarre terms that a familiarity with the litanies of Rabelais could suggest to him. I said: "If she is a sorceress, she hides her game well." "Of cards," added Madame de Girardin with a quickness of mind that never failed her. We tried some further explorations, always fruitlessly, and

Delphine asserted that Balzac had imagined this resource of Quinola in order to be driven by carriage to Auteuil, where he had business, and to procure some pleasant traveling companions. It is necessary to believe, however, that Balzac alone found that Madame Fontaine that we were all seeking together, because, in *Les Comédiens Sans le Savoir*, he depicted her between her hen Bilouche and her toad Astaroth with a fantastic and frightening truthfulness, if those two words can go together. Did he consult her seriously? Did he go to see her as a simple observer? Many passages in *La Comédie Humaine* seem to suggest that Balzac had a kind of faith in the occult sciences, about which the official sciences have still not said their last word.

Around this time, Balzac began to show a taste for old furniture, chests, vases; the least piece of worm-eaten wood that he bought on the Rue de Lappe always had an illustrious provenance, and he created detailed genealogies for his lesser knickknacks. He hid them here and there, always because of those fantastical creditors that I was starting to doubt. I even amused myself by spreading the rumor that Balzac was a millionaire, that he was buying old stockings from dealers in caterpillars to hide onces, quadruples, génovines, crusades, colonnates, double louis, in the manner of Père Grandet; I said everywhere that he had three cisterns, like Aboul-Casem, filled to the brim with garnets, dinars and rials. "Théo will get my throat cut with his jokes!" said Balzac, annoyed and charmed.

That which gave some veracity to my jokes was the new house in which Balzac lived, on the Rue Fortunée, in the Beaujon quarter, less populated then than it is today. He occupied a mysterious little house there that would have suited the fantasies of an ostentatious financier. From outside, one saw over the wall a sort of cupola formed by the arched ceiling of a sitting room and fresh paint on the closed shutters.

When one entered this small house, which was not easy, because the master of this dwelling hid himself with extreme care, one discovered a thousand details of luxury and comfort that contradicted the poverty that he affected. He received me however one day, and I could see a dining room adorned with old oak, with a table, a fireplace, some buffets, some sideboards and some chairs of sculpted wood, that would have made Berruguète, Cornejo Duque and Verbruggen envious; a salon of golden yellow damask, with doors, cornices, plinths and window frames of ebony; a library arranged in armoires inlaid with shell and brass in the style of Boule, and whose door, hidden by the shelves, once closed, could not be found; a bathroom in yellow Breccia, with bas-reliefs of stucco; a domed sitting room, whose old paintings had been restored by Edmond Hédouin; a

gallery lit from above, that I recognized later in the collection of *Le Cousin Pons*. There were on the shelves all sorts of curiosities, porcelain from Dresden and Sèvres, horns of crackled celadon, and on the stairway, which was covered with a rug, some great vases from China and a magnificent lantern suspended by a cable of red silk.

"So have you emptied one of the caches of Aboul-Casem?" I said to Balzac, laughing, confronted with these splendors. "You can see well that I was right to suggest that you are a millionaire."

"I am poorer than ever," he responded while taking on a humble and pious air. "None of this is mine. I have furnished the house for a friend that I await. I am only the caretaker and porter of the building."

I quote here his exact words. This response, he made it in passing to many people who were as shocked as me. The mystery was soon explained by the marriage of Balzac to the woman whom he had loved for a long time.

There is a Turkish proverb that says: "When the house is finished, death enters." It is for this reason that the sultans always have a palace in the course of construction that they are very careful not to complete. Life seems to want nothing to be complete – except misfortune. Nothing is as dreaded as a wish fulfilled.

The notorious debts were finally paid, the dream union completed, the nest made for happiness padded and covered with down; as if they had foreseen his approaching end, those who envied Balzac started to praise him: *Les Parents Pauvres*, *Le Cousin Pons*, where the genius of the author shines in all its radiance, united all opinions. It was too beautiful; nothing more remained for him but to die.

His illness made rapid progress, but nobody believed that there would be a fatal outcome, so much we all trusted in the athletic constitution of Balzac. I thought firmly that he would bury us all.

I was going to take a trip to Italy. And before leaving I wanted to say goodbye to my illustrious friend. He had left in a carriage to collect from customs some exotic curiosity. I drew away reassured, and at the moment that I returned to my carriage, I was given a note from Madame de Balzac, which explained to me obligingly and with polite regrets why I had not found her husband at home. At the bottom of the letter, Balzac had scrawled these words.

"I can neither read, nor write.

"De Balzac."

I have preserved like a relic that ominous line, probably the last that was written by the author of *La Comédie Humaine*; it was, and I did not understand it right away, the final cry, "My God, why have you forsaken me!" of the thinker and of the worker. The idea that Balzac could die did not even occur to me.

A few days after that, I was eating ice cream at the Café Florian, on the Piazza Saint Marco; in my hand I found the *Journal des Débats*, one of the few French papers that was available in Venice, and I saw in it the announcement of the death of Balzac. I almost fell from my chair onto the stones of the Piazza at this sudden news, and my pain was quickly mixed with an impulse of indignation and outrage that was not very Christian, because all souls have an equal value before God. I had just visited the insane asylum on the island of San-Servolo, and I saw there decrepit idiots, doddering octogenarians, human worms who are not even guided by animal instinct, and I asked myself why this luminous brain was extinguished like a flame on which one blows, while tenacious life persisted in these murky heads that were dimly traversed by fickle rays.

Nine years have already passed since that fatal date. Posterity has commenced for Balzac; every day he seems greater. When he was in the company of his contemporaries, he was poorly appreciated, he was seen only in fragments under sometimes unfavorable circumstances: now the edifice that he built rises as one draws further away, like the cathedral of a city that conceals the neighboring houses, and which on the horizon appears immense above the flattened roofs. The monument is not completed, but, such as it is, it terrifies by its enormity, and surprised generations will ask themselves who is the giant who alone has raised these formidable blocks and built so high this Babel that made all of society sing.

Although he is dead, Balzac still has detractors; on his memory are thrown the banal reproach of immorality, the last insult of powerless and jealous mediocrity, or even of total stupidity. The author of *La Comédie Humaine* not only is not immoral, but he is actually a strict moralist. Monarchical and catholic, he defends authority, exalts religion, preaches duty, reprimands passion, and does not accept happiness except in marriage and the family.

"Man," he says, "is neither good, nor bad; he is born with instincts and aptitudes; society, far from corrupting him, as Rousseau maintained, improves him, makes him better; but self-interest develops also his evil tendencies. Christianity, and particularly Catholicism, being, as I said in *Le Médecin de Campagne*, a complete system for the repression of the

depraved tendencies of man, is the most important component of social order."

And with the ingenuity that suits a great man, anticipating the reproach of immorality that will be addressed to him by shoddy spirits, he numbers the irreproachably virtuous characters who are found in *La Comédie Humaine*: Pierrette Lorrain, Ursule Mirouët, Constance Birotteau, la Fosseuse, Eugénie Grandet, Marguerite Claës, Pauline de Villenoix, Madame Jules, Madame de la Chanterie, Eve Chardon, Mademoiselle d'Esgrignon, Madame Firmiani, Agathe Rouget, Renée de Maucombe, without counting among the men, Joseph Le Bas, Genestas, Benassis, the cleric Bonnet, Dr. Minoret, Pillerault, David Séchard, the two Birotteaus, the cleric Chaperon, the judge Popinot, Bourgeat, the Sauviats, the Tascherons, etc.

Rogues are not missing, it is true, in *La Comédie Humaine*. But is Paris populated only with angels?

END

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